

REVIEW ARTICLE · ONE CHAPTER, FIVE OBSTACLES

Socratic Metaphysics

What is left in the Euthyphro when separation is taken away — and whether it is still a theory

THE CHAPTER'S JOB — AND THE SHAPE IT FORCES ON THE ARGUMENT

William Prior's *Socratic Metaphysics* has one thing to prove: that what stands in the *Euthyphro*, minus separation, is already a metaphysical theory. Nobody denies the passages. What five scholars deny — each for a different reason — is that the passages amount to a theory. So the chapter cannot be a single argument. It has to be five.

The proof texts are two: *Euthyphro* 5c–d and 6d–e. Every scholar Prior discusses accepts that they are there, accepts that they are early, and accepts that they use *eidos*, *idea* and *paradeigma*. The disagreement is entirely about what follows. **Dancy** says the passages give conditions on definitions and nothing more. **Vlastos** concedes the ontology outright and denies that it is a *theory*. **Allen** agrees with Prior that it is a theory but distrusts Aristotle's report that Socrates did not separate. **Fine** agrees, and narrows the gap between Socrates and Plato so far that separation almost stops mattering. **Fronterotta** agrees there is a theory and says the forms are *already* separate, so that there is no development to speak of.

Five different denials means five different replies, and that is why the chapter reads as a sequence of confrontations rather than a treatise. Two obstacles come from below — too little is claimed for the passages. Two come from beside — allies who differ on Aristotle and on what forms are. One comes from above — too much is claimed. Each has to be cleared separately, because clearing one does nothing to clear the next.

What the chapter actually settles, and what it does not. It settles that no one in the debate has said what makes a theory metaphysical: Dancy assumes the distinction without defending it, Vlastos draws it where it suits him, and Prior admits he cannot locate it precisely either. The dispute is a *threshold* dispute, and every party has been arguing as though it were a textual one. That is the chapter's real result, and it is a negative one. Prior's positive proposal — seven features that cross the threshold “as a body” — is offered, in his own words, in the hope that “some readers may be convinced.”

WORKS UNDER REVIEW

Prior's chapter is the spine. All six of the other works are held and were read directly; every quotation carries the page of the source itself, and every page reference has been checked against the file it names.

WORK	WHAT IT CONTRIBUTES HERE	ENTERS AT
William J. Prior , "Socratic Metaphysics," ch. 4 of J. Bussanich & N. D. Smith (eds.), <i>The Bloomsbury Companion to Socrates</i> (London, 2012), pp. 68–93, with nn. at p. 337	The chapter under review. Sets the question, states the five positions, and answers each in turn. Also — in a footnote — disowns the chronological framework the whole question is built on.	throughout; §17
R. M. Dancy , <i>Plato's Introduction of Forms</i> (Cambridge, 2004); "Platonic Definitions and Forms," in H. Benson (ed.), <i>A Companion to Plato</i> (Oxford, 2006), pp. 70–84	Obstacle one. A theory of definition with three requirements, and the claim that where Socrates is concerned with definitions "he is not concerned with metaphysics at all."	§§05–06
Gregory Vlastos , <i>Socrates: Ironist and Moral Philosopher</i> (Cambridge, 1991), ch. 2	Obstacle two, and the strangest. Thesis II makes Socrates _E "exclusively a moral philosopher" — and then pp. 57–58 concede him an ontology in so many words.	§§07–08
R. E. Allen , <i>Plato's 'Euthyphro' and the Earlier Theory of Forms</i> (London, 1970); "Plato's Earlier Theory of Forms," in G. Vlastos (ed.), <i>The Philosophy of Socrates</i> (1971), pp. 319–34	The ally, and the source of the position Prior adopts. Real definition; forms as the foundation of dialectic, not a superstructure on it. Distrusts Aristotle.	§§09–10
Gail Fine , <i>On Ideas: Aristotle's Criticism of Plato's Theory of Forms</i> (Oxford, 1993), ch. 5, pp. 44–65	The second ally. Aristotle read as reliable; Socratic and Platonic forms both universals and properties, so the gap narrows to three predicates.	§§11–12

WORK	WHAT IT CONTRIBUTES HERE	ENTERS AT
Francesco Fronterotta , “The Development of Plato’s Theory of Ideas and the ‘Socratic Question’,” <i>OSAP</i> 32 (2007), pp. 37–62	The obstacle from above. Written in reply to Prior 2004: yes there is a theory, and the forms of the early dialogues are already separate. Development disappears.	§§13–14
Prior, W. J. , “Socrates Metaphysician,” <i>OSAP</i> 27 (2004), pp. 1–14	The earlier article the chapter reuses and Fronterotta answers. Quoted throughout the chapter by page.	§08

Scope and method. This reviews one chapter and the five positions it engages. Prior’s own text is quoted at length, and **every one of the five is now quoted from its own pages** — Dancy 2004 and 2006, Vlastos 1991, Allen 1970, Fine 1993, Fronterotta 2007 and Prior’s own 2004 article are all on the shelf and have been read against the chapter. Where Prior’s quotation of a source differs from the source, or stops short of it, that is noted in place (§05 and §14.1 are the two occasions). The order of sections follows the order of the chapter, because the order is the argument: each section is a different obstacle to the same conclusion, and they do not reduce to one another. Passages of Plato are cited by Stephanus number; translations are Grube’s, in Cooper & Hutchinson, *Complete Works* (1997), which is Prior’s own default (n. 3).

OVERVIEW

1. The chapter's job, as a map

PROLOGUE · THE QUESTION, THE TEXTS, AND THE AGREEMENT

1. The question, and the three answers available
2. The two proof texts
3. What all five already agree
4. The threshold problem

PART ONE · THE OBSTACLE FROM BELOW — TOO LITTLE CLAIMED

5. Dancy: definitions, and no metaphysics
6. Against Dancy: the undefended threshold, and the package that was never added up
7. Vlastos: the ontology conceded, the theory denied
8. Against Vlastos: Quine's criterion, and three ways "everyone agrees" misleads

PART TWO · THE OBSTACLES FROM BESIDE — ALLIES WHO DIFFER

9. Allen: real definition, and the earlier theory of Forms
10. Where Prior and Allen part: Aristotle, and two senses of separation
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PART THREE · THE OBSTACLE FROM ABOVE — TOO MUCH CLAIMED

13. Fronterotta: the forms are already Forms
14. Against Fronterotta: separation as an answer to a question not yet asked — incl. §14.1 the objection he does not answer, and §14.2 the one over many in both directions

CODA · WHAT THE CHAPTER SETTLES

15. The seven features
16. Where the threshold actually lies — incl. §16.1 the criterion Prior cites and does not use
17. The premise Prior does not believe — note 2
18. What the chapter establishes, and what it leaves open — incl. §18.0 the internal audit, seven tensions graded
19. The whole thing as a map

oo The chapter's job, as a map

Read this once; everything after it is elaboration.

One conclusion, five obstacles, and the obstacles do not stand in a line. Two of them say the passages claim *too little* to be a theory; two are allies who claim the same thing for different reasons and disagree with Prior about the details; one says the passages claim *too much* for there to be any development at all. Clearing any one leaves the others exactly where they were.

OBSTACLE	WHAT IS DENIED	ON WHAT GROUND	PRIOR'S REPLY, IN A LINE
Dancy from below	That the <i>Euthyphro</i> passages are metaphysical at all	They state conditions on definitions . Metaphysics begins with the Argument from Relativity, in the <i>Phaedo</i> .	Your own Transmission Theory is metaphysics by your own admission — and you never check whether the whole package already adds up.
Vlastos from below	That the ontology is a theory , or Socrates a metaphysician	Everyone assents to it as a matter of course; and Socrates never asks “What is form?”	By Quine's criterion he is committed. And the “everyone agrees” claim is false — Meno does not.
Allen from beside	Nothing — but denies Aristotle's reliability	On Aristotle's own account of separation, the early forms are just as separate.	Side with Fine: take Aristotle at his word, and keep the two senses of separation apart.
Fine from beside	Nothing — but makes the gap smaller	Socratic and Platonic forms are both universals and properties; only three predicates differ.	Agreed about Socrates. But separation changes what kind of entity a form is — property to substance.
Fronterotta from above	That there is any development to describe	The early forms are already separate; “two worlds” is only a metaphor for what was there.	Two Worlds separation answers an epistemological question the early dialogues never raise. His second objection — immanence vs. universality — goes unanswered (§14.1).

THE THING THAT MAKES THIS CHAPTER WORTH READING TWICE

The dispute is not about the Greek. All five read *Euthyphro* 5c–d and 6d–e the same way. What divides them is a question none of them answers: *how much does a set of claims have to contain before it counts as a metaphysical theory?* Prior gets this into the open by quoting a reviewer against Dancy — “I worry about the lack of attention given to the question as to what counts as a metaphysical theory” — and then, in his own conclusion, concedes that he cannot fix the threshold either: “Exactly where the threshold of metaphysical significance lies is uncertain.”

Once that is visible, the five obstacles stop looking like five readings of a text and start looking like five placements of a line. Dancy and Vlastos put it at separate existence. Fronterotta puts it so low that the early dialogues are already across. Prior puts it at the One over Many, and then declines to insist, arguing instead that his seven features cross it “as a body, wherever it lies.”

THE WHOLE DISPUTE IN TWO SENTENCES — reconstructed, not quoted**The anti-metaphysical premise**

A set of claims is metaphysical only if it posits entities that exist *separately* — in their own right, apart from the things that have them. Short of that, you have rules for talking.

The metaphysical premise

A set of claims is metaphysical if it says what there is and how those things are individuated. Universals with identity conditions and a causal role qualify, separate or not.

Neither sentence is anyone’s. **Both are mine** — the premises each side must be assuming, since neither side states one. What follows is the evidence for reading them that way, and §16 is where the reconstruction is tested against a criterion that *is* stated.

TWO CAVEATS ON THE BOX ABOVE, SINCE EVERYTHING TURNS ON IT

1 · The first premise is Prior’s imputation, not his opponents’ claim. What is on the page is Prior’s report: “Dancy (like Vlastos) identifies ‘having a metaphysical view’ with having ... ‘a grandiose theory of separately existing Forms’” p. 75 . Dancy states no criterion at all — that is Zeyl’s complaint and Prior’s. And **Vlastos’s stated criterion is something else entirely:** reflective investigation. “One qualifies as a linguist when one makes language an object of reflective investigation ... And this is what S_E never does” 1991: 58 . Separation is how Vlastos characterises *Platonism*; it is not how he defines *metaphysics*. §08 answers the criterion Vlastos actually gave; the box above answers the one Prior attributes to him.

2 · The second premise conjoins two sources that nobody conjoins. “Says what there is, with identity conditions” is Quine, and Prior uses it explicitly p. 80; 2004: 7–8 . “And a causal role” is Allen and Fine. The conjunction is a reconstruction, and §16.1 shows that the Quinean half and the framework Prior cites as his foundation are not compatible.

WHERE THE SEPARATION CRITERION COMES FROM — AND THE SLIDE IN IT

Nobody invented the first premise. It descends from **Aristotle**, *Metaphysics* M.4 1078b30–31: “Socrates did not make universals or definitions separate, but they separated them.”

But notice what Aristotle is doing there. He is distinguishing **Plato from Socrates** — separation is his mark of what makes a theory *Platonic*. It is not his mark of what makes a set of claims metaphysical, and it cannot be: at M.9 1086b2–7 he says Socrates “was *right* not to separate them,” which would be an odd thing to say of a man who on that account had no view.

The criterion is inherited and put to a different job. A mark of Platonism becomes a mark of ontology as such. That slide is the root of the dispute, it is made by no one on purpose, and once it is named, Prior’s “I do not think this is a reasonable place to put the threshold” stops being a preference and becomes a diagnosis.

PROLOGUE

ABOUT THIS PART

Before any of the five is heard, three things have to be fixed: what is being asked, what text is being asked about, and how much of the answer is already common ground.

IN SHORT

Almost everything is common ground. What is contested is a single word — “theory” — and nobody has defined it.

Sections 01-04

the question · the texts · the agreement · the threshold

00

The agreement is larger than the dispute.

*It is easy to read this literature as five rival interpretations of two short passages. It is not that. All five interpreters agree on what the passages say, on which words matter, and on which dialogue they belong to. Four of the five agree that the *Phaedo* contains a theory of Forms and that the *Euthyphro* lacks something the *Phaedo* has.*

What they disagree about is whether what the *Euthyphro* has, without the thing it lacks, is enough to be called a theory — and that is a question about where to put a line, not about what the Greek says. §04 makes the line explicit, because the rest of the chapter is unreadable without it.

Read §04 carefully. Every one of the five confrontations that follows is a disagreement about the same threshold, conducted in different vocabulary each time.

01 The question, and the three answers available

William J. Prior

1946–2026 · Santa Clara University · Ph.D. Texas 1975

Author of the chapter under review, and of the 2004 article it reuses. Professor Emeritus of Philosophy at Santa Clara; died 23 April 2026, a few weeks short of his eightieth birthday.

KEY WORKS HERE

- “Socratic Metaphysics” (2012), the chapter reviewed
- “Socrates Metaphysician,” *OSAP* 27 (2004)
- *Unity and Development in Plato’s Metaphysics* (1985)
- *Socrates* (2019)

Where he matters:

throughout · §08 (the reply to Vlastos is his) · §17 (the disowned chronology)

Prior opens by refusing to let the question stay vague. “Did Socrates have a metaphysics?” splits into two prior questions — what a metaphysics is, and who Socrates is — and he answers both before starting.

*Metaphysics is concerned with what lies at the foundation of things, the principles underlying reality. In this essay, that will mean **primarily an ontology, a theory of ‘what there is’**.*

Prior, “Socratic Metaphysics” **p. 68**

That is a deliberately modest stipulation, and it does a great deal of work later: it is the reason Vlastos’s concession at §07 turns out to be fatal to Vlastos’s own thesis. On the second question Prior is equally brisk. Of the five, “only Gregory Vlastos insists that he is seeking the historical Socrates. The rest are content to deal with the Socrates of the Platonic dialogues” **p. 68** — and that, Prior says, is “the only Socrates about whom we have information adequate to provide an answer to the ontological question.”

THE QUESTION, ONCE THE FOG IS CLEARED

Does the Socrates of the early dialogues possess an ontology — a theory of “what there is”?

Prior notes that this formulation is forced on him by the developmentalist framework, which confines the question to the early group. He then lists the three answers the framework allows:

- **Yes, the Platonic one.** Socrates espouses the metaphysics of the middle dialogues. (The unitarian answer, which the developmentalist rejects.)
- **Yes, a predecessor of it.** Allen, Fine, Prior — and, on his own terms, Fronterotta.
- **No — Socrates is innocent of metaphysics.** Dancy and Vlastos.

The stakes are not scholastic, and Prior says why at some length. The answer “decisively shapes our understanding of the nature of Socrates’ philosophical inquiry, which is central to everything we know about him” **p. 71**. If the Socrates of the early dialogues has a theory of forms, then he stands much closer to the Socrates of the middle dialogues than Dancy or Vlastos can allow — and Vlastos’s whole solution to the Socratic problem, which depends on the two being irreconcilable, loses its foundation.

02 The two proof texts

Two passages, quoted in full, because the entire chapter is a quarrel about them.

Prior labels them E1 and E2, and every one of the five scholars anchors his or her reading in one or both.

(E1) SOCRATES: ... So tell me now, by Zeus, what you just now maintained you clearly knew: what kind of thing do you say that godliness and ungodliness are, both as regards murder and other things; or is the pious not the same and alike in every action, and the impious the opposite of all that is pious and like itself, and everything that is to be impious presents us with **one form (idean, d4)** or appearance in so far as it is impious?

EUTHYPHRO: Most certainly, Socrates.

SOCRATES: Tell me then, what is the pious, and what the impious, do you say?

Euthyphro **5c-d**, trans. Grube — Prior p. 69

(E2) SOCRATES: Bear in mind then that I did not bid you tell me one or two of the many pious actions but **that form (eidos, d11) itself that makes all pious actions pious**, for you agreed that all impious actions are impious and all pious actions pious **through one form (idea, e1)**, or don't you remember?

EUTHYPHRO: I do.

SOCRATES: Tell me then what this **form (idean, e4) itself** is, so that I may look upon it, and using it as a **model (paradeigmati, e6)**, say that any action of yours that is of that kind is pious, and if it is not that it is not.

Euthyphro 6d–e — Prior p. 69

Prior reads four commitments straight off the surface, and it is worth noticing that *none of the five disputes any of them*:

WHAT THE PASSAGES PUT ON THE TABLE

1 A universal

"The claim that there is one form for all the instances of piety, a 'One over Many', marks piety as a universal, a common property" p. 69 .

2 A cause

"The claim that it is 'through' one form of piety that all pious things are pious marks piety as a 'cause' of pious actions" p. 70 .

AND WHAT FOLLOWS FROM THEM

3 A standard, hence self-predication

"The statement that forms are *paradeigmata* ... marks piety as a standard for the application of the term 'pious'. Paradeigmatism leads to self-predication" p. 70 .

4 An essence

Socrates' rejection of definition by distinguishing mark at *Euthyphro* 9e–11b "indicates that the definition of piety must describe its nature, or essence" p. 70 .

Prior's own summary of the situation. “This impressive looking set of claims **appears to constitute a metaphysical theory**, one that strongly resembles the middle period theory of Forms. How does it differ from that theory? **Primarily on the issue of separation.**” p. 70

03 What all five already agree

It is worth setting out the common ground in one place, because the size of it is the reason the chapter has the shape it has. If the five disagreed about the text, Prior could argue about the text. They do not, so he cannot.

AGREED BY ALL FIVE

1. Plato has a metaphysics — in Vlastos's phrase, which Prior adopts as the chapter's point of departure, “a grandiose theory of ‘separately existing’ Forms” **Vlastos 1991: 48**, found in the *Phaedo*, *Symposium* and *Republic*.
2. Those Forms are universals, causes, paradigms or standards, and in some sense self-predicational.
3. The *Euthyphro* is an early dialogue. “All of the authors considered in this essay regard the *Euthyphro* as an early dialogue” p. 69.
4. E1 and E2 are the proof texts, and they use *eidos*, *idea* and *paradeigma*.

AGREED BY FOUR OF THE FIVE

That the difference between the early passages and the middle-period theory is **separation** — that the forms of the early dialogues do not exist apart from their participants, and the Forms of the middle dialogues do. Fronterotta is the exception, and denies precisely this.

What divides the four who agree about separation is not whether it is the difference, but *how much difference it makes*. Prior sets that out with unusual precision:

*For some interpreters (Allen and me, in particular), separation is a serious issue, marking a large-scale difference between the theories and requiring a difference in the kind of entities forms can be said to be (unseparated forms being **properties**, but separate Forms being **substances**). For **Fine**, in contrast, the difference between the unseparated forms of the early dialogues and the separated Forms of the middle dialogues is much more modest, with forms of both kinds being treated as properties. For **Francesco Fronterotta**, the germ (at least) of separation, and thus of the middle period theory of Forms, is already present in the early theory.*

Prior p. 70

04 The threshold problem

The question the whole literature is really about, and which nobody in it has answered.

Prior does not use the word “threshold” until his conclusion, but the concept is doing all the work from the first page. The five positions are not five readings of a text; they are five placements of a line, and the line is: **how much must a set of claims contain before it is a metaphysical theory?**

WHERE EACH PARTY PUTS THE LINE

High — at separate existence

Dancy and **Vlastos**. Nothing short of “separately existing” Forms counts. Everything below that is rules for definitions (Dancy) or unreflective common sense (Vlastos). Prior’s comment: “I do not think this is a reasonable place to put the threshold” p. 92 .

Low — already crossed in the *Euthyphro*

Fronterotta. If the object of definition must be universal, unchangeable and stable, “it obviously cannot belong to the physical world” — so separation is there from the start, and the two-worlds imagery of the middle dialogues is a “narrative change at most.”

Between them: **Allen**, **Fine** and **Prior**, who all place the line below separation and above nothing — and who differ from each other about where exactly, and about what separation does to the entities on either side of it.

The most damaging thing in the chapter is not any of Prior’s five replies. It is a quotation he takes from a review of Dancy by Donald Zeyl, which he deploys against Dancy and which turns out to indict the whole discussion:

I worry about the lack of attention given to the question as to what counts as a metaphysical theory, and what distinguishes such a theory from one that isn’t metaphysical. That distinction is crucial to Dancy’s overall argument, yet it seems assumed without much support.

Donald Zeyl, review of Dancy 2004 — quoted at Prior p. 75

Prior presses the point in his own voice, and the sentence is the hinge of the chapter:

“He claims that it is a metaphysically innocent precursor, but he does not show that it is, for he does not offer an account of what makes a theory metaphysically innocent.” p. 75

And then, seventeen pages later, Prior concedes the same about himself. That symmetry — the objection turning on its author — is treated at §16.

PART ONE

ABOUT THIS PART

Two scholars who say the passages claim too little. They agree with each other about the conclusion and disagree about almost everything else.

IN SHORT

Dancy denies there is metaphysics in the early dialogues. Vlastos concedes there is an ontology and denies it is a theory. The second concession is the more useful of the two, and Prior builds on it.

Sections 05-08

Dancy's theory of definition · the reply · Vlastos's Thesis II · the reply

01

The obstacle from below

Both of these are developmentalists, and both draw the line at separate existence. But the shape of the denial is different in each case, and so the reply has to be different. Dancy says the Euthyphro gives you a theory of definition — three requirements on what a good answer to “What is F?” must do — and that a theory of definition is not a theory of anything that exists. Vlastos does not say that. Vlastos says Socrates has an ontology, in so many words, and then denies him the title of ontologist on the ground that he never reflects on it.

The two denials fail for different reasons, and Prior treats them separately. Against Dancy the reply is that his own theory already contains metaphysics on his own admission. Against Vlastos the reply is that the premise about universal assent is simply false of the text.

Bottom line: Dancy never says what would make a claim metaphysical; Vlastos says what would — reflective investigation — and then applies the test unevenly.

05 Dancy: definitions, and no metaphysics

R. M. Dancy

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The purest anti-metaphysical reading. Constructs a Theory of Definition from the refutations, and holds that metaphysics begins only with the *Phaedo*.

KEY WORKS HERE

- *Plato's Introduction of Forms* (2004)
- "Platonic Definitions and Forms" (2006)
- *Two Studies in the Early Academy* (1991)

Where he matters: §§05–06 · and, as the model for the position adopted in the companion review, its §30.

The purest version of the anti-metaphysical position, and the one Prior treats with the most respect.

Dancy is a developmentalist who divides the corpus into a Socratic group (*Charmides*, *Euthyphro*, *Hippias Major*, *Laches*, *Lysis*, *Protagoras*, *Republic I*), a doctrinal group (*Phaedo*, *Symposium*, *Republic*), and the *Meno* as transitional. What the early dialogues contain is not metaphysics but a **theory of definition**, which Dancy constructs from their refutations rather than finding stated in them.

DANCY'S THREE CONDITIONS OF ADEQUACY

What a definition has to do — and nothing about what exists

- **Substitutivity.** The definiens and the definiendum must be substitutable *salva veritate*: the definiens must state a necessary and sufficient condition. Prior: "just a standard feature of definitions and contains nothing controversial" p. 73 .
- **Paradigm.** The definiens "must give a paradigm or standard by comparison with which cases of its definiendum may be determined."
- **Explanatory.** The definiens "must explain the application of its definiendum."

The last two "are clearly stated in (E2)" p. 73 — which is the whole difficulty, since E2 is also the metaphysician's proof text.

The load-bearing claim is the one Prior quotes twice, because everything turns on it:

*That Theory of Definition will contain one fairly straightforward condition of adequacy for a definition, below called the “Substitutivity Requirement,” another more difficult one, the “Explanatory Requirement,” and a third quite puzzling one, the “Paradigm Requirement.” **The latter two especially will feed into the Theory of Forms. They do not, however, entail that theory; where Socrates is concerned with definitions, he is not concerned with metaphysics at all** (against this see, e.g., Allen 1970). We shall see the turn toward metaphysics when we get to the *Phaedo*.*

Dancy, “Platonic Definitions and Forms,” in Benson (ed.), *A Companion to Plato* p. 71

Prior quotes the middle of that sentence and drops what follows the semicolon’s end. The parenthesis matters:

Dancy names Allen 1970 as the position he is denying, on the page where he states the denial. The line of §§05–10 is therefore not a coincidence of the chapter’s arrangement — Dancy and Allen were already opposed, in print, and Prior is standing behind Allen.

What marks the transition, for Dancy, is the **Argument from Relativity** — and it is not in the Socratic dialogues:

- 1 There exists a form of F (e.g. the Beautiful).
- 2 Ordinary F things are also not-F (beautiful things are also ugly).
- 3 The form is never not-F (the Beautiful is never ugly).
- ∴ The form of F is not the same as any ordinary F thing.

“This argument does not appear in the Socratic dialogues, though it is anticipated in the *Hippias Major*. It does, however, appear in the middle dialogues” p. 72. Dancy identifies it with the Argument from Flux that Aristotle uses to separate Socrates from Plato — and he accepts Aristotle’s testimony that “Socrates did not make the universals or the definitions exist apart” (*Metaphysics* M.4, 1078b30–31).

The admission Prior will use against him

Dancy connects the Paradigm and Explanatory Requirements by what he calls a **Transmission Theory of Causality**: the cause transmits to the effect a quality it possesses itself, so the cause of something’s being F is the perfect paradigm of F-ness. And of that theory he says:

Dancy calls the Transmission Theory ‘a piece of metaphysics although not yet the Theory of Forms’.

Dancy 2006: 77 — at Prior p. 73

Prior immediately inserts his objection in parentheses, and it is the most efficient sentence in the chapter:

“(He does not consider, however, whether his whole package — the Explanation and Paradigm Requirements, strengthened Self-Predication and the Transmission Theory of Causation, when connected with the One over Many principle, which he does not include in his theory of definition — do not amount to the theory of Forms such as that presented in the *Phaedo*.)” p. 74

Where Dancy draws the line, in his own words

Two passages show the placement precisely. The first is on the *Hippias Major*, where Hippias concedes that justice exists and that by justice things are just:

*Almost but not quite, and here close doesn’t count. So far we have only conceded the existence of the beautiful, and no one can suppose that this concession lets in the super-beautiful described in the Symposium. All that Socrates needs is that there is **something to be defined**, as subject for his ‘what is it?’ question.*

Dancy, *Plato’s Introduction of Forms* p. 78 — quoted at Prior p. 74

And the second, on why the *Hippias Major*’s argument does not establish a theory of Forms: “Socrates says nothing whatever to indicate that he has an overarching interest in the **transcendental existence** of the Form of the Beautiful” (2006: 79). Prior’s gloss is flat and correct: “This remark indicates clearly that Dancy regards **only a theory of transcendental Forms** as a metaphysical view” p. 73 .

WHAT DANCY IS ACTUALLY CLAIMING — FROM HIS OWN BOOK

It matters, for §06, that Dancy’s denial is not a claim about Plato’s mind. He says so explicitly, in a passage Prior does not quote:

when I deny (as I shall) that the Euthyphro has a “Theory of Forms,” I do not suppose that I am commenting on what was or was not in Plato’s mind at the time he wrote the Euthyphro. I am talking only about what is required by the argument of the Euthyphro.

Dancy, *Plato’s Introduction of Forms* p. 11

So the disagreement between Dancy and Prior is not about history and not about Greek. It is about what a given body of argument *requires* — which is exactly the kind of question a threshold governs.

06 Against Dancy: the undefended threshold, and the package that was never added up

Prior concedes almost the whole of Dancy's positive account, and attacks one gap in it.

The concession is generous and specific:

*Dancy provides an **excellent account** of the theory of definition in the Socratic dialogues, and of the development or unfolding of the theory of Forms in the *Phaedo* and *Symposium*. A proponent of the Allen/Fine/Prior account ... can accept much of what he says.*

Prior p. 75

Then the objection, in two parts.

OBJECTION ONE · THE MISSING ACCOUNT

i He shows the wrong thing

“He shows that the theory of definition is not equivalent to the theory of ‘separately existing’ Forms of the middle dialogues, but **he does not show that it is not a precursor** to that theory. Indeed, he insists that it is a precursor to it. He claims that it is a **metaphysically innocent** precursor, but he does not show that it is, for **he does not offer an account of what makes a theory metaphysically innocent**” p. 75 .

ii The identification he shares with Vlastos

“Dancy (like Vlastos) identifies ‘having a metaphysical view’ with having, in Vlastos’s words, ‘a grandiose theory of separately existing Forms’. Neither Dancy nor Vlastos considers the more modest theory of unseparated forms ... to be a metaphysical theory, **even though it seems to me to be the forerunner of Aristotle’s ontology**” p. 75 .

OBJECTION TWO · THE PACKAGE

iii The sum was never taken

Dancy grants that the Transmission Theory is “a piece of metaphysics.” He grants the Paradigm and Explanatory Requirements. He grants strengthened Self-Predication. He leaves the One over Many out of his theory of definition — and never asks what the four together come to. Prior’s charge is not that any single item is decisive; it is that **the addition was never performed**.

iv Real definition, unaddressed

“It would seem that Dancy does not believe that the Socratic definitions he describes are **real definitions**... If he held that they were, he would have to consider the claim that there was a metaphysical view in the Socratic dialogues” p. 76 . A real definition defines a thing, not a term — and defining things is ontology by Prior’s §01 stipulation.

And a disagreement about size

The one substantive textual difference concerns the *Hippias Major*’s beautiful girl. For Dancy the step from “any beautiful girl is also ugly” to the general Argument from Relativity is a large one, requiring a generalisation Socrates does not make. For Prior:

*For me the step is a **small one**, and is almost inevitable when one realizes that there is nothing special about the example of a maiden, that she simply typifies the entities in the phenomenal world. In general, I think the Socratic dialogues anticipate the Platonic theory of Forms in many ways such as this.*

Prior p. 76

HOW STRONG IS THIS REPLY?

Strong on the threshold. The complaint that Dancy never defines metaphysical innocence is well-founded, and Zeyl's review makes the same complaint independently. Dancy's working criterion — as Zeyl reconstructs it, that a claim intelligible to naive interlocutors and accepted as obviously true is not metaphysical — is one Dancy never states and could not easily defend. Zeyl's reply is unanswerable as it stands: "Why, one might wonder, should a philosophically naïve interlocutor be incapable of understanding a metaphysical proposition?"

Weaker on the package. The parenthesis at p. 74 is an invitation, not an argument. Prior asks whether the four items *amount to* the *Phaedo*'s theory; he does not carry out the comparison, and he does not say which of the *Phaedo*'s commitments the package would still be missing. Since the answer — on Prior's own account — is *separation*, the parenthesis assumes exactly what is in dispute. It shows that Dancy owes an argument. It does not supply one.

And note the asymmetry of burden. Prior repeatedly says Dancy "does not show" that the early material is non-metaphysical. But Dancy could reply, with equal justice, that Prior does not show that it is — both are appealing to a threshold neither has drawn. §16 is where this comes home.

07 Vlastos: the ontology conceded, the theory denied

Gregory Vlastos

1907–1991 · Princeton,
then Berkeley

The most influential position in the field. Socrates_E is “exclusively a moral philosopher” — and yet pp. 57–8 concede him an ontology outright.

KEY WORKS HERE

- *Socrates: Ironist and Moral Philosopher* (1991), ch. 2
- “Socrates,” British Academy lecture (1988)
- *Socratic Studies* (1994, posth.)

Where he matters: §§07–08 · §04 (the high threshold) · §16

The most influential position in the field, and the one that concedes most of what it means to deny.

Vlastos divided the corpus, distinguished Socrates_E from Socrates_M, identified the first with the historical Socrates and the second with Plato, and listed ten differences. Thesis II is the one that matters here, and he says so himself:

IIB. Socrates_M had a grandiose metaphysical theory of ‘separately existing’ Forms [...]

IIA. Socrates_E has no such theory.

Vlastos, *Socrates: Ironist and Moral Philosopher* p. 47

I move directly to Thesis II, the most powerful of the ten: as I shall try to show in the balance of the present chapter, the irreconcilable difference between Socrates_E and Socrates_M could have been established by this criterion even if it had stood alone.

Vlastos p. 53

From the absence of Socrates_M’s theory Vlastos infers that Socrates_E is “exclusively a moral philosopher” p. 47. And then, having set out the two conditions on definition that E1 and E2 impose, he writes the passage Prior labels V1 — and which, read on its own, reads like an argument for the opposite conclusion:

(V1) In assuming that these two conditions can be met S_E is making a **substantial ontological commitment**. He is implying that what there is contains not only spatio-temporal items, like individuals and events, but also **entities of another sort whose identity conditions are strikingly different** since they are “the same” in persons and in actions which are not the same: justice here and justice there and again elsewhere, the same in different individuals and occurrences, real in each of them, but real in a way that is different from that in which they are real, its own reality evidenced just in the fact that it can be instantiated self-identically in happenings scattered widely over space and time, so that if justice has been correctly defined for even a single instance, the definiens will be true of every instance of justice that ever was or ever will be anywhere — in Greece or Persia, on earth or on Olympus or in Hades.

That there are things which meet this strong condition is a piece of ontology firmly fixed in Socrates_E’s speech and thought. **He has this ontology.**

Vlastos pp. 57–58 — quoted at Prior pp. 76–7 as (V1)

Vlastos sees the problem coming and meets it in the next sentence: “Can he have an ontology without being an ontologist? Why not?” The answer is an analogy:

The belief in the existence of a physical world independent of our own mind ... is a solid piece of ontology, as entrenched in the mind of the average Athenian then as in that of the average New Yorker now. Does this make an ontologist of either of them? Why should it? **Can’t one have a language without being a linguist?** One qualifies as a linguist when one makes language an object of **reflective investigation**. One would qualify as an ontologist if one made ontology an object of reflective investigation. **And this is what S_E never does.**

Vlastos p. 58

The test is then applied. Socrates asks what piety is, what beauty is — but never what form is:

The search for those general properties of forms which distinguish them systematically from non-forms is never on his elenctic agenda. He asks: What is the form piety? What is the form beauty? And so forth. **What is form? he never asks.** He is perplexed about many things, but never about the fact that what there is contains forms ... He banks on their reality with the same **unreflective, unexamined, unargued, undefended assurance** with which the man in the street banks on the reality of trees and stones.

Vlastos pp. 58–59

The denial, in one sentence. “A belief is not a theory if everyone’s agreement with it can be presumed as a matter of course — if it is unproblematic for everyone, in need of explanation and justification for no one. **This is the vein in which S_E believes in the reality of forms.**”

Vlastos p. 59

The contrast drawn: what Socrates_M does that Socrates_E does not

Vlastos’s case is comparative, and the comparison is precise. In the *Protagoras*, faced with the leading relativist of the age, Socrates declines the ontological argument altogether:

*Plato could hardly have made it clearer that the interests of Socrates in this dialogue are **exclusively ethical**. Brought up face to face with the premier relativist of the day, the chance to debate ontology virtually thrust upon him, Socrates_E turns it down.*

Vlastos p. 63

In the middle dialogues the same existence claim becomes contestable. It is a “posit” at *Republic* 596a and a “hypothesis” at *Phaedo* 100b — “To the existence of the F, which had been regularly conceded to Socrates_E by all of his interlocutors without contest, Socrates_M refers as a highly contestable thesis” p. 63. Prior reports the four categorical features Vlastos then attributes to the Forms — inaccessible to the senses, absolutely changeless, incorporeal, existing “themselves by themselves” — and the conclusion:

This is the heart of Plato’s metaphysics: the postulation of an eternal self-existent world, transcending everything in ours, exempt from the vagaries and vicissitudes which afflict all creatures in the world of time, containing the Form of everything valuable or knowable, purged of all sensory content.

Vlastos p. 76 — at Prior p. 78

ONE FOOTNOTE WORTH HAVING

Vlastos knew Allen’s position and did not dismiss it. Attached to the sentence “it is gratuitous to credit him ... with a theory of forms” is this note:

*For an **attractive version** of this view, which allows S_E to have a piece of S_M ’s ontology — though only a modest one, still a far cry from S_M ’s two-world theory of reality — see **Allen, 1970: 67ff.** et passim.*

Vlastos p. 59 n. 52

So the disagreement between Vlastos and Allen is, on Vlastos’s own showing, about how much of Socrates_M’s ontology Socrates_E gets — not about whether he gets any.

08 Against Vlastos: Quine’s criterion, and three ways “everyone agrees” misleads

Prior’s own contribution, first published as “Socrates Metaphysician” (2004) and reused here.

Prior begins by pocketing the concession, and he is explicit about what it does to the map:

*Now Vlastos’s response to the claim that there is an ontology in the Socratic dialogues is **remarkable**: as we saw above, he **admits that Socrates_E has this ontology** (V1). He goes on to argue that though he has an ontology, Socrates_E is nonetheless still exclusively a moral philosopher. Before I go further, let me note that from my perspective **this concession puts Vlastos in the camp of those who, like Allen, Fine and myself, attribute to the Socrates of the early dialogues a metaphysical view.***

Prior p. 80

What is left of Vlastos’s denial is then two theses, and Prior answers each.

REPLY ONE · AGAINST “NOT A THEORY”

i Quine’s criterion of ontological commitment

“My response to the first point is the fact that, **whether or not it counts as a theory, Socrates is ontologically committed to forms**. According to Quine’s criterion of ontological commitment, Socrates is committed to the existence of justice, piety and the like: **he treats them as values of bound variables**” p. 80, citing Prior 2004: 7–8. This sidesteps the word “theory” entirely: commitment is settled by the logical form of what is said, not by how confidently it is said.

REPLY TWO · AGAINST “NEVER ASKS WHAT FORM IS”

ii The test is too restrictive — and self-defeating

“True, Socrates does not ask ‘What is Form?’ in the early or Socratic dialogues, **but neither does he ask it in later dialogues, such as the *Phaedo* and *Republic*, which Vlastos admits are metaphysical. Not until the *Parmenides* does Socrates ask, ‘What is Form?’**” p. 80.

iii And definition already is investigation of a form

“the definitional statements Socrates is seeking are **identity statements**, and it does not matter which side of the identity sign the definiendum is on. So when Socrates says he is seeking the definition of piety, and piety is a particular form ... he is at the same time engaged in serious investigation into the nature of a form. On the assumption that the quest for the definition of a moral virtue is a quest for the nature of a particular form, **moral inquiry and metaphysical are inseparable**” p. 81.

Reply (ii) is the sharpest thing in the chapter. Vlastos’s criterion for being an ontologist is reflective investigation of ontology as such; the *Phaedo* and *Republic* do not contain it either; and Vlastos calls them metaphysical. So the criterion, applied evenly, either promotes the *Euthyphro* or demotes the *Phaedo*.

Three ways the “everyone agrees” premise misleads

Prior calls this “perhaps the most serious objection Vlastos made,” and answers it in three moves — the third of which is a straightforward textual refutation.

1 · Universal acceptance does not disqualify. “The heliocentric theory of the solar system is a theory that is accepted by everyone in the civilized world” p. 81 .

2 · Whether it is a theory depends on who holds it. “An ontology of physical objects existing in space may not be a theory to the unreflective ‘man in the street’, but it may be a theory nonetheless **to a philosopher**” — and Vlastos’s own New Yorker analogy concedes the distinction. “Whether or not a statement is part of an ontological theory, then, is not a matter of the statement itself but **the way in which it is held and by whom**” p. 82 .

3 · The premise is false. Meno does not agree. “not every character in the dialogues takes the existence and definition of a common character to be unproblematic. To be specific, **Meno does not**. He explicitly rejects Socrates’ comparison between the definition of virtue and the definition of a bee or health or strength. Subsequent discussion not only fails to define virtue but also leads to Meno’s famous sceptical question, how is inquiry possible? **The idea that virtue is a common character is anything but unproblematic for Meno**” p. 82 .

Prior adds two supporting observations from the same page: that Socrates is *careful* to secure explicit assent to his existence claims — from Protagoras, Hippias and Euthyphro alike — and that his interlocutors “often show that they do not really understand such claims even when they have assented to them.” Hippias and Euthyphro find the idea of a common character “intellectually daunting,” and “it takes much subsequent discussion to sort matters out.”

THE OBVIOUS OBJECTION, AND PRIOR’S PRE-EMPTION

Objection: the *Meno* is transitional, not early — on Vlastos’s own scheme it belongs to the group he thinks post-dates the elenctic dialogues. So a refutation drawn from Meno’s resistance is not a refutation about Socrates_E.

Reply: “It is, however, in its first third, **an elenctic dialogue, as Vlastos notes** (Vlastos 1988: 144). The discussion of the ontology of definition in the *Meno* is germane to the ontology of the elenctic dialogues” p. 82 . And a second pre-emption: if it is objected that the *Meno*’s doctrine of Recollection is linked in the *Phaedo* to separate Forms, so that the *Meno*’s common characters must be separate too — “the common characters of the *Meno* are not separately existing Forms, but ‘forms’; **there is no trace of separation in the *Meno***” p. 82 .

The two conclusions, verbatim

*1. The Socrates of the elenctic dialogues is a moral philosopher. The form his moral philosophy took was that of enquiry into the nature of the moral virtues. The assumption underlying this enquiry is that the virtues are characteristics, properties, common to many individual persons and actions. Without this assumption it is hard to see how moral enquiry could go forward. **The assumption is ontological, metaphysical in character. The fact that it is held not casually, but in the face of philosophical objections, marks it as a philosophical view.***

Prior 2004: 13–14 — at Prior p. 82

2. Vlastos was incorrect in his claim that the Socrates of the early dialogues was exclusively a moral philosopher ... **The ontology of the elenctic dialogues differs from that of the middle dialogues only in a single respect: separation. This is a huge difference and it is, strictly, an incompatibility.** Thus, the ontology of the elenctic dialogues is in this one respect incompatible with that of the middle dialogues. In other respects, however, it is compatible with that ontology and should be seen as the **precursor or first stage** of that theory.

Prior 2004: 14 — at Prior p. 82

Note what conclusion 2 costs him. Prior calls separation “a huge difference” and “strictly, an incompatibility.” That is a large concession for someone arguing that the early material is already a theory — and it is exactly the concession Fronterotta will exploit at §13, from the other direction.

PART TWO**ABOUT THIS PART**

Two allies. Neither is an obstacle to the conclusion; both are obstacles to the version of it Prior wants.

IN SHORT

Allen supplies the theory Prior adopts and distrusts the witness Prior relies on. Fine trusts the witness and narrows the gap so far that Prior's "huge difference" starts to look small.

Sections 09–12

Allen · Aristotle and two separations · Fine · properties or substances

02

The obstacles from beside

These two sections are the reason the chapter cannot be a single argument even among friends. Allen, Fine and Prior all hold that there is a theory of forms in the early dialogues; they hold it on the same textual basis, E1 and E2; and they still disagree about two things that matter. One is whether Aristotle's report can be trusted. The other is what separation does — whether it changes a form's properties or changes what kind of thing a form is.

Prior sides with Fine against Allen on the first and with Allen against Fine on the second. The result is a position that is nobody else's, and he says so.

Bottom line: the interesting disagreements in this literature are among the people who agree.

09 Allen: real definition, and the earlier theory of Forms

R. E. Allen

1931–2007 · Northwestern

“The leader of the minority view,” and the source of the position Prior adopts. Forms as the foundation of dialectic, not a superstructure on it.

KEY WORKS HERE

- *Plato’s ‘Euthyphro’ and the Earlier Theory of Forms* (1970)
- “Plato’s Earlier Theory of Forms” (1971)
- *Studies in Plato’s Metaphysics*, ed. (1965)

Where he matters: §§09–10 · §14 (the functional argument) · §14.1 (the dissolution Prior cannot use)

The source of the position Prior adopts. “His works remain, after four decades, the classic statement of that view.”

Allen finds his evidence where everyone does — in E1 and E2 — and reads the forms there as universals, causes, self-predicating paradigms and essences. What he adds is an account of *why* that set of claims has to be metaphysical rather than merely regulative: because the two roles the forms play are inseparable.

*That theory is both logical and metaphysical. **Logically**, Forms play a regulative role in dialectic: as antecedents of ‘it’ in the question ‘What is it?’ they determine the kinds of answer which are acceptable, and more importantly, unacceptable, in Socrates’ search for definition. They define the conditions for deciding when dialectic has succeeded, and when it has failed. **Metaphysically**, Forms affect the career of the world: they are the real natures of things, and the world is what it is because they are what they are.*

Allen, *Plato’s ‘Euthyphro’ and the Earlier Theory of Forms* pp. 67–8

The join is **real definition**, and Allen states the equivalence as tightly as it can be stated:

*These two sides of Plato's theory meet in the notion of real definition. Dialectic is governed by rule, and directed toward the nature of things. Its rules are determined by its aim. **To say that Forms exist is to say that real definition should be pursued; to say that real definition should be pursued is to say that Forms exist.** The theory of Forms in the *Euthyphro* is **not a superstructure gracelessly added on to dialectic: it is the foundation of dialectic.** Without it, dialectic would not proceed by the rules it uses, or work toward the goal at which it aims. **Socratic moral inquiry is inquiry about reality.***

Allen p. 68

That last clause is the answer to Vlastos in a single line, thirty years before Prior gave it in Quine's vocabulary: if Socratic inquiry is inquiry about reality, the question whether Socrates is "also" a metaphysician does not arise.

What real definition is, and what it is not

Prior reports Allen's account carefully, because it does the work Dancy's theory of definition does not:

REAL DEFINITION, PER ALLEN 1971

Analysis of essence, not a report on usage

- Real definition "is analysis of essence, rather than stipulation as to how words are used or a report as to how they are in fact used" Allen 1971: 327 .
- It is **not** nominal definition plus an existence claim; "the existential import is taken for granted in the early dialogues."
- Real definitions concern essence, and the essence of a thing is "the nature of something which is" 1971: 328 .

Hence the conclusion Prior takes over wholesale: "The fact that the forms Socrates seeks in the *Euthyphro* are universals, standards and essences implies that the kind of definition he seeks is real definition; this in turn entails that the search is a metaphysical one" Prior p. 83 .

Allen's own version of the anti-nominalist point is more vivid than any paraphrase, and it turns on a criterion of existence he takes from Plato himself:

*This echoes Plato's own criterion of ontological commitment in the *Sophist* (247e), which he supposed was shared by Gods and Giants alike: it is that the mark of being is **power**, power to act or to be acted upon. **A difference, to be a difference, should make a difference.** If Forms are to exist, we might expect them, **not as it were to just sit there, but to do honest work, to affect the career of the world.** This they do; for we shall find that, in the early dialogues, Forms are **causes.***

Allen 1970, ch. on Essence and Reference

Prior quotes the 1971 version of the same passage — “They do honest work ... Beauty is not a word, not a thought, not a concept. **It is an existing thing**” Allen 1971: 329 — and adds Allen’s explanation of why Euthyphro can accept all this without a struggle. The theory is metaphysical, but it is “**continuous with common sense**” 1971: 330 :

*His question is hardly one which common sense, left to its own devices, will ask. But it is a question to which common sense may certainly be led... The progress of dialectic involves passage from the naive existence claim that ‘there is such a thing as holiness’ to the highly sophisticated existence claim that **there is an essence of holiness, and that it can be defined**... the commitment to essence is then **latent** in the common sense use of words.*

Allen 1971: 331

That paragraph is the reply to Vlastos’s “man in the street”. Vlastos infers from the ease of assent that no theory is present. Allen accounts for the ease of assent *and* keeps the theory: the commitment is latent in ordinary usage, and dialectic is the process of making it explicit. Same datum, opposite conclusion — and Allen’s explanation covers more of the text, since it also explains why the interlocutors then get into difficulty.

Not *the* theory of Forms

Allen is emphatic that what he has found is not the middle-period doctrine, and his statement of the difference is the one Prior adopts and Fronterotta attacks:

*[T]hat theory of the choir of heaven and the furniture of earth found in the *Phaedo*, *Republic*, and other middle dialogues... The philosophy of the middle dialogues is a **nest of contrasts**: Being and Becoming, Appearance and Reality, Permanence and Flux, Reason and Sense, Body and Soul, Flesh and the Spirit. Those contrasts are rooted in an **ontology of two Worlds, separated by a gulf of deficiency**.*

Allen 1971: 332 — at Prior p. 84

And he explains the change by an epistemological pressure that arises *about* Socratic dialectic rather than *within* it — the passage that becomes Prior’s weapon against Fronterotta at §14:

*Plato’s account in the middle dialogues is conditioned by **problems in epistemology which the early dialogues had not faced**. Those problems arose over scepticism and a priori knowledge. **They arose not in Socratic dialectic, but about it**; specifically, they arose when Plato turned to deal with the question of **how Socratic dialectic, as a search for Forms or essences, is possible**.*

Allen 1970: 157 — at Prior p. 85

The pressure enters at the *Meno* — which Allen calls an “early middle” or “boundary” dialogue — in Meno’s paradox; the answer is Recollection; and in the *Phaedo* Recollection is tied to the Forms. Hence his final formula, which Prior quotes as the summary of the whole metaphysical interpretation:

*The middle dialogues do not abandon the ‘What is it?’ question. They pursue it in the light of a new ontology. The theory of Forms in the middle dialogues, then, is **neither the same theory as that of the early dialogues, nor a different one. Not different because it contains the earlier theory as a part. Not the same because it is directed towards issues which the early dialogues do not raise.***

Allen 1971: 334 ; cf. 1970: 163–4 — at Prior p. 85

10 Where Prior and Allen part: Aristotle, and two senses of separation

“My agreement with Allen is nearly complete” — and the residue is two items, both consequential.

*If Gregory Vlastos holds the majority opinion about Socratic metaphysics, **Allen is the leader of the minority view.** My agreement with Allen is nearly complete; we hold the same view of Socratic metaphysics, but we have slightly different views on separation. We also disagree about the testimony of Aristotle; **like Fine, I take Aristotle’s view of Socrates’ ontology to be reliable, whereas Allen is critical of it.***

Prior p. 70

DISAGREEMENT ONE · THE WITNESS

i Allen rejects Aristotle's report

Allen “rejects the view of Aristotle that Socrates ‘did not separate the forms’ in the early dialogues. **On Aristotle's own understanding of ‘separation’**, which requires that ‘the Ideas are numerically distinct from their instances, exist independently of their instances, and are ontologically prior to their instances’ (Allen 1970: 133), **Allen insists that the forms of the early theory are just as ‘separate’ as those of the later theory”** 1970: 136, cf. 147; at Prior p. 84 . Prior flags this in his own note 9 as a position Allen holds “elsewhere.”

ii Prior sides with Fine

Aristotle's testimony is taken as reliable, and given a specific content: “When Aristotle says that Socrates was seeking the universal or the essence of things but ‘did not make the universals or definitions exist apart’, **I interpret him to mean that Socrates had a theory of universals, but not the Platonic theory of separately existing ones”** Prior 2004: 4; at Prior p. 79 .

DISAGREEMENT TWO · THE WORD

iii Two things called “separation”

“In his book Allen defined ‘separation’ in two ways: **first, in terms of the independent existence of the forms, and second, in terms of the ‘gulf of deficiency’** between Forms and their phenomenal participants, and **I focused on the second sort of separation in my article. Let us call the second sort of separation ‘Two Worlds separation’”** p. 90 .

iv Which dissolves the apparent conflict

Allen's claim that the early forms are “just as separate” is about the *first* sense — numerical distinctness and ontological priority. Prior's claim that separation is absent from the early dialogues is about the *second*. Allen himself says the difference “does not consist in the fact of separation, but **the way in which separation is conceived”** 1970: 147 .

THE DISTINCTION IS DOING MORE WORK THAN PRIOR ADMITS

Splitting “separation” into independent existence and Two Worlds deficiency is a real advance, and it is what lets Prior hold his own position while calling Allen an ally. But it has a cost he does not register.

If the early forms are already separate in Allen’s first sense — numerically distinct, existing independently, ontologically prior — then the early theory is already an ontology of independently existing universals, and it is much harder to say what Dancy and Vlastos are denying. On this reading their target has already conceded everything they care about.

And if it is not, then Prior owes an account of the first sense too, and he does not give one. He says only that the second sense is the one he focused on. The chapter therefore leaves the strongest version of its own thesis unstated: either the early forms exist independently, in which case say so, or they do not, in which case Allen is wrong and should be answered rather than accommodated.

11 Fine: the same entities, better defended**Gail Fine**

Cornell, emerita · long associated with Oxford

Reads Aristotle as reliable and narrows the Socrates–Plato gap to three predicates. Supplies, without being asked, the answer to Fronterotta’s objection.

KEY WORKS HERE

- *On Ideas* (1993), ch. 5
- *Plato on Knowledge and Forms* (2003)
- *The Possibility of Inquiry* (2014)

Where she matters:

§§11–12 · §14.1 (universality from immanence) · §14.2 (belief before knowledge)

The ally who makes the gap smallest — and, by doing so, makes Prior’s “huge difference” hardest to maintain.

Fine’s chapter differs from the rest in method: it is primarily about Aristotle, not about the dialogues. She works from three *Metaphysics* passages, which Prior reproduces in her translations as F1–F3, and which are the external evidence the whole debate turns on.

*(F1) But Socrates was concerned with moral questions, and not at all with the whole of nature; he was seeking the **universal** (katholou) and was the first to turn his thought to definitions. Plato agreed with him; but because of this (Heraclitean view) he supposed that this (defining) applied to **different things** (heterōn) and not to sensibles — for, he thought, it is impossible for the common definition to be any of the sensibles, since they are always changing.*

Metaphysics A.6, 987b1–b7, trans. Fine **Fine 1993: 44–6**

*(F2) Now Socrates was concerned with the moral virtues, and he was the first to seek universal definitions in connection with them... For there are just two things one might fairly ascribe to Socrates — inductive arguments and universal definitions, both of which are concerned with the starting point of knowledge. But **Socrates did not make universals or definitions (horismous) separate (chorista), but they (the Platonists) separated them.***

Metaphysics M.4, 1078b17–19, 23–5, 27–31

*(F3) Socrates motivated this (view) ... through definitions; but he did not separate (universals) from particulars. **And he was right not to separate them.** This is clear from the results. For it is not possible to acquire knowledge without the universal; but **separating it is the cause of the difficulties arising about the ideas.***

Metaphysics M.9, 1086b2–7

F3 is easy to pass over and should not be. Aristotle is not merely reporting that Socrates did not separate; he is endorsing the non-separation and blaming the difficulties of the theory of Ideas on the separating. The witness Prior chooses to trust has a view of his own about which side was right.

What Fine takes Aristotle to establish

*Socrates believes that correct answers to ‘What is F?’ questions specify forms; forms are the objects of definition where, as we have seen, definitions are **real definitions**. The ontological correlates of real definitions are **real essences, non-linguistic universals that explain why things are as they are.***

Fine, On Ideas **p. 49**; quoted at Prior p. 86

Prior attaches a one-line note of his own to that quotation — “The relation to Allen’s view is clear” (n. 14) — and the point is not decorative: Fine arrives at Allen’s conclusion by a completely different route, from Aristotle rather than from the *Euthyphro*, and that convergence is the strongest thing the metaphysical interpretation has going for it.

*Aristotle takes Socratic forms to be universals not just in the sense that they are or can be **in more than one thing at a time** but also in the sense that they are **real essences, explanatory properties**.*

Fine 1993: 50 — at Prior p. 86

Prior’s summary of what she attributes to Socrates: “Socratic forms are thus real essences, universals, explanatory properties rather than meanings, self-predicative paradigms. **They are not separate from their participants**” p. 86. Note the divergence from Allen already visible here: Fine has forms as *properties*, and explicitly not as *meanings* — where Allen’s account is a referential theory of meaning, on which “the meaning of a term is the characteristic to which it refers, which is a Form” Allen 1970: 125.

Separation, in Fine’s hands, becomes surprisingly weak

The passage Prior quotes here is the most striking concession in the chapter after Vlastos’s V1, and it comes from the scholar most committed to trusting Aristotle:

*Nothing said in the middle dialogues seems to me to involve clear commitment to separation. None the less, separation fits well with the tenor of the middle dialogues, and the casual way in which separation emerges in the *Timaeus* perhaps suggests that Plato takes it for granted. So I shall **assume** that Aristotle is right to say that Plato separated forms, though it is important to be clear that **Plato never argues, or even says, that forms are separate**.*

Fine 1993: 61 — at Prior p. 87

And earlier, on what the middle-dialogue arguments do establish: “The argument from compresence shows that forms are different from both sensible particulars and sensible properties. **But it does not show that forms are separate**: that is, that they can exist whether or not the corresponding sensible particulars exist” Fine 1993: 60.

The consequence, which Prior does not draw. If separation is nowhere argued for or even asserted in the middle dialogues, and is accepted on Aristotle’s authority plus the “tenor” of the texts, then the one difference Prior calls “a huge difference ... strictly, an incompatibility” rests on external testimony rather than on Plato. That is a strange foundation for a threshold.

How far Fine closes the gap

SOCRATES AND PLATO, ON FINE'S ACCOUNT

The same

Both hold forms to be **universals or properties**, introduced for metaphysical and epistemological reasons; both hold that forms are **self-predicative paradigms in virtue of their explanatory role**; both accept self-predication in the **broad** sense (BSP) — the form is F in a different way from its participants, namely by explaining their F-ness. Neither treats forms as **perfect particulars** or as **meanings**.

Different — three predicates

Plato says forms are **non-sensible**, **perfect** and **separate**. On paradigmaticism: “whereas Socrates accepts only **weak** paradigmaticism, Plato accepts **perfect** paradigmaticism” 1993: 63 . And on the status of forms as universals: “Neither the fact that forms are self-predicative nor the fact that they are paradigms jeopardizes their status as universals” 1993: 64 .

Fine's conclusion: “Platonic forms are **not different entities** from Socratic forms. Rather, Plato is attempting to offer what he views as **a better account of the same entities**” 1993: 64 .

She is explicit that Plato is not innovating against Socrates but defending him: “he is offering what he takes to be the most plausible **defence** of Socrates, or developing Socrates' views in what he takes to be the most plausible way”

1993: 64 .

12 Where Prior and Fine part: properties or substances

One disagreement, stated in three sentences at the very end of the chapter, and it is the load-bearing one.

*I am in **complete agreement** with Fine's postulation of an early theory of forms, and especially with her treatment of early Platonic forms as properties. I think that this is what Aristotle meant when he said that Socrates 'did not make the universals or definitions exist apart': that he accepted universals, but not separately existing ones. **I do not think, however, that Fine is right to claim that the separated Forms of the middle dialogues continue to be properties. I think that separation transforms forms into Forms, properties into substances.***

Prior p. 93

The consequence he draws is a chain, and it is the closest the chapter comes to an argument for the importance of separation:

1 Separation transforms a property into a substance — a thing existing in its own right rather than a characteristic of things.

2 That yields “a new concept of self-predication, according to which **Forms become perfect instances** of their relevant properties.”

3 And with it a new account of the relation: “**participation becomes resemblance** to that instance.”

∴ So the difference is not a matter of adding three predicates to the same entities; it is a change in what kind of entity is being talked about.

Prior then closes the door on the obvious follow-up: “Aristotle’s interpretation of the Platonic version of Forms, with all its complexities, is, however, **beyond the scope of this chapter**” p. 93 .

THE ONE PLACE WHERE THE CHAPTER’S ARCHITECTURE STRAINS

This disagreement is doing an enormous amount of work and receives about a hundred and fifty words. It is what makes separation “a huge difference” rather than a modest addition; it is therefore what distinguishes Prior’s position from Fine’s *and* from Fronterotta’s; and it is the premise that lets him call the early theory a precursor rather than the same theory.

It is also asserted rather than argued. Fine has an account of why forms stay properties: their self-predication is broad (BSP), so being perfectly F does not require being an instance. Prior’s step 2 presupposes narrow self-predication for the middle dialogues — and Fine has already argued that Plato, like Socrates, holds the broad version. The disagreement therefore reduces to a prior dispute about self-predication in the *Phaedo*, and that dispute is not conducted here.

Which places the burden exactly where §06 placed Dancy’s. Prior objects that Dancy assumes his threshold; on properties-versus-substances Prior assumes his. The chapter is more even-handed than it means to be.

PART THREE**ABOUT THIS PART**

The obstacle from the other side: a scholar who grants the conclusion and then takes it too far for Prior to accept.

IN SHORT

Fronterotta wrote in reply to Prior 2004. He agrees there is a theory of Ideas in the definitional dialogues, and holds that the Ideas are already separate — so there is nothing left to develop.

Sections 13-14

Fronterotta's case · Two Worlds separation and the question that produces it

03

The obstacle from above

Every obstacle so far has been an attempt to keep metaphysics out of the early dialogues, or a friendly dispute about its shape. This one is the reverse. Fronterotta accepts Prior's textual case, extends it, and then uses it against the developmental framework that Prior, Allen and Fine all share. If the early forms are separate, then the middle dialogues add nothing ontological, and the two-worlds imagery is — his word — a metaphor.

So Prior, who has spent eighteen pages arguing that the passages claim more than his opponents allow, has to spend the last four arguing that they claim less than his ally does.

Bottom line: the reply turns entirely on Allen's point that the middle-period apparatus answers a question the early dialogues never pose.

13 Fronterotta: the forms are already Forms

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Wrote in reply to Prior 2004. Grants the theory of Ideas in the definitional dialogues and holds that the Ideas are already separate — so there is no development to describe.

KEY WORKS HERE

- “The Development of Plato’s Theory of Ideas and the ‘Socratic Question’,” *OSAP* 32 (2007)
- *Methexis* (2001)

Where he matters: §§13–14 · §14.1 (the objection he raises and abandons) · §04 (the low threshold)

“Fronterotta is a unitarian, or, to use his term, an ‘anti-developmental’.”

The aim is stated in his own words, as Prior reports it: to show that “an anti-developmental thesis (like Allen’s or more radical) is **wholly plausible**” **Fronterotta 2007: 40**. And the route runs through four definitional dialogues, with a progression inside them.

STAGE ONE · CHARMIDES AND LACHES

1 Failure by insufficient universality

The definitions fail because they give examples rather than universal formulae. The requirement can be stated as **extensional equivalence** between definiens and definiendum — which, as Prior notes in n. 15, “is reminiscent of Dancy’s substitutivity requirement.”

STAGE TWO · HIPPIAS MAJOR AND EUTHYPHRO

2 Failure of a different order — the causal-ontological turn

Now the definition “must refer back to the proper nature of the relevant object, that is, to that Form or Idea that, ‘when added’ ... to anything, ‘makes it beautiful’... and it is the cause (1) that produces the beauty of/in all the beautiful things or (2) by which all other beautiful things become beautiful”

2007: 42 . The *Euthyphro* then adds the form as *paradeigma*.

The positive statement is unambiguous:

*An answer to the Socratic question ‘what is X?’ can now be given **solely by indicating a unique and universal object** — qualified by Plato as an ‘Idea’ or ‘Form’ itself — that is **always unchangeable and identical to itself** and yet ‘present’ in a multiplicity of particular things, to which, by virtue of its ‘presence’, it confers that same property whose true nature it embodies.*

Fronterotta, OSAP 32 (2007) p. 44 ; quoted at Prior p. 88

*The question raised in the definitional dialogues, emphasizing the need for a definition, leads to positing Ideas as **the real beings one has to know beforehand** ... in order to put forward an appropriate definition: on these terms, **it seems to me beyond doubt that one can legitimately speak of a ‘theory of Ideas’ in Plato’s early dialogues.***

Fronterotta 2007: 49 — at Prior p. 89

And then the turn against his allies

Up to here Fronterotta is compatible with Allen, Fine and Prior. What follows is not. Against Allen — whom he calls “one of the rare scholars who has ... recognized a true philosophical meaning in the theory of Ideas in the definitional dialogues” 2007: 57 — he argues:

that the difference between Ideas and sensible things, in the early dialogues, already consists in a real and concrete separation between two kinds of beings.

Fronterotta 2007: 57 — at Prior p. 90

He concedes that this separation “never takes on the ‘mythical’ form of the juxtaposition between two separated worlds” — and then downgrades that concession to nothing: it “represents **a narrative change at most**,” an “enlargement” of the hierarchy “from a ‘geographical’ point of view.” The argument for it is a single inference:

“For, if the object to be defined and known must be universal, unchangeable, and stable, it obviously cannot belong to the physical world.” Fronterotta 2007: 57

I tend to believe that this onto-epistemological principle, which plausibly explains the introduction of Ideas, forcing their status to be separated from the physical world and justifying their set of functions, is on no account subject to development in Plato’s thought.

Fronterotta 2007: 57

The charge of prejudice

The last move is aimed at the Socratic question itself, and Prior reports it without softening. The attempt to find the historical Socrates in the early dialogues “falls apart” once there is a theory of separate forms there, and it was resting on

*an implicit **exegetical prejudice** ... consisting in the dogmatic assumption that Plato’s early dialogues represent a faithful portrayal of Socrates’ philosophical activity.*

Fronterotta 2007: 58 — at Prior p. 90

The prejudice, on his account, is what requires the elimination of the theory of forms from the early dialogues and the drawing of a sharp early/middle line. Remove it, and “Plato already inaugurates an original philosophical trend from the early dialogues, especially regarding the onto-epistemological framework of the theory of Ideas” **2007: 59**.

PRIOR ADOPTS THE PHRASE — AGAINST HIS OWN SIDE'S OPPONENTS

The remarkable thing is that Prior, who is about to reject Fronterotta's conclusion, keeps his diagnosis and turns it on Dancy and Vlastos:

"I suspect that the real reason for rejecting the metaphysical interpretation of the Socratic dialogues is **antecedent commitment to the radical developmentalist framework of interpretation, what Fronterotta calls an 'exegetical prejudice'**. The evidence in favour of an early theory of forms cannot be decisive because we 'know', prior to inquiring, that the Socrates of the early dialogues was 'exclusively a moral philosopher'" **p. 92** .

So the unitarian's weapon is borrowed by a developmentalist to use on other developmentalists. That is a fair indication of how little the labels are doing in this debate.

14 Against Fronterotta: separation as an answer to a question not yet asked

The reply is Allen's, and it is the only place in the chapter where Prior argues from the *function* of a doctrine rather than its content.

Prior grants the whole of Fronterotta's positive case: "Naturally, I have no criticism of Fronterotta's introduction of forms in the early dialogues, **but are these forms 'Forms'?**" **p. 90** . And he immediately locates the dispute where §10 located it — in the ambiguity of the word:

"The question turns on the meaning of 'separation', and this is not as clear as it might be." **p. 90**

Fronterotta, on Prior's reading, downplays Two Worlds separation by calling it mythological, geographical, a metaphor. The reply is that the metaphor is doing philosophical work, and that the work is *epistemological*:

As Allen argued, the separation of the Forms in the 'middle' dialogues is a response to questions about Socratic dialectic that the Socratic dialogues do not raise. These questions are epistemological in nature. They are raised for the first time in the Meno, in Meno's paradox. The Meno offers a solution to the problem of Socratic dialectic in the doctrine of Recollection; the Phaedo connects this doctrine with the theory of Forms. It is in the Phaedo that Socratic 'forms' become 'Forms', and the change is due to Plato's consideration of these new questions about the possibility of inquiry.

Prior **p. 90**

A second cause is added, and it is Dancy's:

*It is also due to Platonic meditation on the imperfection of sensible objects, the fact that for every example of F-ness one finds, there is some respect in which it is not-F. **The paradigm requirement of Socratic definition, enunciated by Dancy and accepted by Allen, among others, requires as a definition an object that is F in all respects.** Believing that such objects could not be found in the phenomenal world, **Plato posited a separate world in which they existed.** This was a consequence of Dancy's 'Argument from Relativity', introduced for the first time in the *Phaedo*, but adumbrated in the *Hippias Major*.*

Prior p. 90

THE ASYMMETRY THE REPLY RESTS ON

Prior concedes half of Fronterotta's ground and holds the other half: "Fronterotta **could** argue that this hint indicates that Platonic separation is present already in the Socratic dialogues, **but the same cannot be said for the epistemological considerations mentioned above**" p. 90 .

That is: the *Hippias Major* may anticipate the Argument from Relativity, so one of the two causes of separation may be early. But Meno's paradox is demonstrably not in the definitional dialogues, and Recollection is its answer. A doctrine whose job is to answer a question cannot be present before the question is.

*In brief, it seems to me that **Two Worlds separation is not found in the Socratic dialogues, but marks a new development in the so-called middle dialogues.** With this development comes another, a change in ontological status of the Forms. **Socratic forms are properties of phenomenal objects, however independent of those objects they may be; Platonic Forms are self-subsistent substances,** though they generate properties of objects through participation. One may argue that Platonic Forms are properties, as does Fine, but **I think one cannot eliminate the change in ontological status between forms and Forms.***

Prior p. 91

14.1 · The objection he does not answer — immanence and universality

Fronterotta plants it in a parenthesis on his second page, and Prior never comes back to it.

Fronterotta opens by summarising Prior 2004 in three numbered claims. The third carries an aside:

Prior argues that: (1) a theory of Ideas had been present since Plato's early dialogues; (2) this theory implies the existence of certain ideal entities that are **not separated from sensible things, but immanent to them**; (3) their function is exactly the one Aristotle included among the purposes of Socratic enquiry, i.e. **to serve as universal terms**, thereby fulfilling the need for a definition — an issue Socrates' character often raises in the early dialogues (**although it is not clear how an Idea that is immanent in something may at the same time work as a universal term that is predicated of that very thing and provides a definition of it**).

Fronterotta, "The Development of Plato's Theory of Ideas and the 'Socratic Question'," OSAP 32 (2007) pp. 37–8

THE OBJECTION, UNPACKED

What immanence seems to require

If the Idea is *in* the pious action — a constituent of it, its *ousia*, the thing that makes *this* action pious — then it is something belonging to that action, located wherever the action is.

What the definitional role seems to require

If the Idea is what answers "What is the pious?", it must be one thing said of many, general over them, and available to be predicated of each. That looks like something standing over the action, not in it.

Fronterotta's charge is that Prior needs both and has explained neither, and that the second is the reason the Ideas must be **separate**.

The aside is not idle. It is the seed of the whole article, because the tension is what Fronterotta will use to argue that the early Ideas cannot be immanent and must therefore already be separate — his §5 conclusion at §13 above. When he reaches the problem in his own voice, at the end of his fourth section, he states it in full:

Yet a problem arises here: if in the early dialogues Ideas are kept distinct from the multiplicity of particular things, is it not paradoxical that they represent at the same time the proper being of that multiplicity and that, furthermore, the relationship between the Ideas and the particular things is conceived as the presence or the addition of Ideas in/to those things?

Fronterotta 2007 pp. 50–1

And then he declines to solve it

This is the decisive fact about the objection, and it is easy to miss because it comes in the same breath:

*The matter is extremely difficult and we shall leave it at that: it is, however, noteworthy that Plato does not seem troubled by such a question, as in the middle and late dialogues he continues to describe participation of the sensible things in Ideas as **the presence of separated Ideas in things that participate in them.***

Fronterotta 2007 p. 51

The footnote to that sentence closes the door explicitly:

*My conclusion is that this **fluctuation between different conceptions of the relationship Ideas–sensible things remains an unresolved dilemma in Plato’s thought.***

Fronterotta 2007 p. 51 n. 19

And he says it a third time, in his own survey of developmentalist arguments, where the same point is used *against* the developmentalists:

*the relationship between things and Ideas is described **in all dialogues** either as ‘presence’ (παρουσία) of Ideas in the participating things or as likeness of participating things to the ideal ‘models’ ... What is more, at least up to the Parmenides, Plato does not take a clear stand on the modalities of participation, and **one is forced to admit that the problem is left unsolved even in middle and late dialogues.***

Fronterotta 2007 p. 56, argument (II)

WHAT THAT DOES TO THE OBJECTION

It converts it into a *tu quoque* that cannot discriminate. If “the Idea is present in the thing and is also what the thing is defined by” is unclear, it is unclear in the *Phaedo* too — where participation is still described as presence, and where, on Fronterotta’s own account, the Ideas are separate *and* present in what participates in them. An objection that lands equally on both readings is not a reason to prefer either. **It is a problem about methexis, not about the early theory.**

Prior’s answer: there is none

Neither paper takes it up. Prior 2004 could not have — Fronterotta was written in reply to it. But the 2012 chapter, which reports Fronterotta at length across three pages, never mentions the parenthesis. The word “immanent” occurs once in the whole chapter, and it is a different point: Fronterotta’s complaint that immanence and transcendence vocabulary appear in both groups of dialogues **Prior p. 89, citing Fronterotta 2007: 54**. The reply Prior does give — that Two Worlds separation answers a question raised first in the *Meno* — is an answer to a different objection.

So the honest report is: the objection stands unanswered in the chapter. What follows is not a reconstruction of what Prior says, but a statement of the three answers available to him from the sources he has already endorsed — and of the reason he can use only one of them.

Answer one — Fine: being in many at once *is* what a universal is

The most direct dissolution is in the book Prior calls himself in “complete agreement” with, on the pages he cites for other purposes. Fine derives universality *from* immanence rather than setting the two against each other:

*he says that the form of piety is some one thing, **the same in (en; Eu. 5d1–2; cf. Ch. 159a1–2, 158e7) everything that is pious**; it is that feature of things by which they are pious. ... We saw before that Aristotle takes Socratic forms to be universals, and we can now see why he does so. For since the form of piety is in everything that is pious, it is simultaneously in more than one thing at a time, and so it fits one of Aristotle’s descriptions of universals.*

Fine, *On Ideas* pp. 49–50

On this account there is no double role to reconcile. To be a universal *is* to be capable of being in more than one thing at a time; the immanence is not a second, competing fact about the form but the very thing that makes it general. And Fine diagnoses precisely why the tension seems to arise — by distinguishing two kinds of one-over-many argument, after Armstrong:

Realist one over many arguments posit universals to explain **sameness of nature**; if a group of objects are all *F*, they are *F* in virtue of sharing a genuine property, the property of *F*. ... **Semantic** one over many arguments posit universals to explain **the meanings of general terms** and, indeed, universals just are the meanings of those terms. On the account of Socrates that I have provided, **he offers not a semantic but a realist one over many argument**. For, as we have seen, he wants to know **not the meanings of general terms, but the properties in virtue of which things are as they are**.

Fine p. 50

That is the diagnosis. Fronterotta’s parenthesis says the Idea must “work as a **universal term** that is **predicated of** that very thing.” *Term* and *predicated* are semantic vocabulary. On a semantic one-over-many the puzzle is real — a meaning is a poor candidate for something located in an action. On a realist one it does not arise, because a property is exactly the kind of thing that is both had by many particulars and true of each. The objection is generated by the reading of Socrates that Fine, Allen and Prior all reject.

Answer two — Allen: there is no immanence to reconcile

Allen 1970 devotes a section to the question, under the heading “The Immanence of Forms,” answering W. D. Ross. His move is more radical than Fine’s: he denies that the “in” locution carries any ontological weight at all.

*All of the expressions Professor Ross cites are used quite ordinarily in Greek with abstract nouns; to say, for example, that there is justice in an action is merely another way, and an ordinary way, of saying that an action is just. Since Forms are the meanings of abstract nouns, the use of such expressions is **metaphysically neutral**: if the claim that Forms are immanent in their instances merely summarizes facts of linguistic usage, the claim is true but, so far as the issue of ontological status is concerned, **vacuous**.*

Allen, *Earlier Theory* pp. 145–6

And if “immanent” is meant in some stronger, technical sense, Allen’s complaint is that nobody has ever given it one: “because **no independent meaning has been assigned to ‘immanence’**, neither truth nor falsity attach to Professor Ross’s claim that Forms are immanent in their instances in the early dialogues, if that claim is meant as an account of their ontological status” p. 147. Which leads to the sentence that makes this answer unusable for Prior:

The truth of the matter is that in a strong sense of term Forms are as ‘separate’ from their instances in the early dialogues as they are later on. For they are not identical with their instances, and ontologically prior to their instances. That is, they exist ‘apart’.

Allen p. 147

Answer three — Prior’s own materials, unassembled

Prior 2004 has the pieces. He calls the early forms “common characters” and “immanent characters” throughout, and identifies the resulting position by name:

*What remains when the idea of ‘separation’ has been removed? As Aristotle saw, a theory of **universals**. Aristotle describes Socrates as ‘seeking the universal’ in the ethical matters he investigated ... but Socrates ‘did not make the universals or the definitions exist apart’ (1078^b30), as the Platonists did. Thus, **Allen and Aristotle seem to agree that a theory of universal forms can be attributed to Socrates**.*

Prior, “Socrates Metaphysician,” OSAP 27 (2004) p. 4

An immanent universal is not an unstable hybrid; it is the standard Aristotelian category, and Prior says in the 2012 chapter that the unseparated theory “seems to me to be **the forerunner of Aristotle’s ontology**” p. 75. He also quotes Vlastos describing the early forms in exactly Fronterotta’s terms without registering any difficulty: “What he is talking about are **forms existing only ‘in’ their instances, never ‘separately’ from them**” Vlastos 1988: 140, at Prior 2004: 7. Neither Vlastos nor Prior treats that as paradoxical, and on the Aristotelian reading it is not.

THE BIND — WHY PRIOR CAN USE ONLY ONE OF THE THREE

Allen’s answer is closed to him. It dissolves the tension by making the early forms separate in the strong sense — numerically distinct, ontologically prior, existing “apart.” Prior’s whole position is that the early forms are *properties of* phenomenal objects and that separation is what converts a property into a substance (§12). He cannot take Allen’s dissolution without conceding Fronterotta’s conclusion by another route. This is the unstated cost of §10: having split “separation” into two senses and declined to say where the early forms stand on the first, he has also forfeited the answer that turns on it.

Fine’s answer is open to him, and he half-takes it. He endorses “her treatment of early Platonic forms as properties” p. 93, which is all the answer needs. But he then denies that the *middle-period* Forms remain properties — and once Forms become substances, the *Phaedo*’s continued talk of presence in participants becomes exactly the puzzle Fronterotta describes, now in Prior’s own middle dialogues. **He solves it for Socrates by a move that recreates it for Plato.**

The *tu quoque* is open to him and costs nothing. Fronterotta concedes three times over that the presence relation is unexplained everywhere in the corpus. That alone disarms the objection as a reason to prefer separation. It is the reply the chapter should have made, and did not.

14.2 · The one over many, run in both directions

The objection of §14.1 has a sharper form, and a mirror image. Neither favours separation, and the pair of them turn out to be the engine of the corpus.

Take three people — *a, b, c* — and three pious actions, **pa, pb, pc**. On the Allen–Prior reading the one form **P** is present in all three. Two questions can be pressed, and they pull opposite ways.

THE TWO DIRECTIONS

Downward — from the one to the many

If **P** is one and is *in* three separate actions, is all of it in each, or part of it in each? Either answer looks fatal. This is §14.1's objection at full strength.

Upward — from the many to the one

If instead **P** is what we arrive at by generalising from *pa*, *pb* and *pc*, then what licensed collecting those three in the first place? Only **P** could have. So **P** is presupposed, not derived.

The first threatens immanence. The second threatens abstraction. **Between them they force one particular position** — and it is not Fronterotta's.

Downward: the objection is Plato's, and it is aimed at the separated Forms

The downward version is not a modern complaint. It is Parmenides' first objection to young Socrates at *Parmenides* 131a–e, and its structure is a dilemma:

1 **P** is one.

2 **P** is present in *pa*, in *pb*, in *pc*.

3 *pa*, *pb*, *pc* are numerically distinct and separate.

4 If one thing is *in* several separate things, then either **all** of it is in each or a **part** of it is in each.

5a Part in each → **P** is divided → **P** is many. Contradicts 1.

5b All in each → one and the same thing wholly in three places → **P** is separate from itself.

Socrates offers the sail — one sail covers many people — and Parmenides answers that then each person is under a *part* of the sail, which is horn 5a again. He then runs the reductio: the part of Largeness in a large thing would have to be *smaller* than Largeness itself.

THE HIDDEN PREMISE IS 4

Whole-or-part exhaustion is a truth about **bodies**. Half a loaf in each of two rooms; there is no third option. Whether it holds of anything else is precisely what is at issue — and the realist answer is that “universal” *names* the category of entities for which it fails. Aristotle's own mark of a universal, which Fine cites, is that it can be **in more than one thing at a time**. On that account premise 4 is not refuted so much as inapplicable.

AND SEPARATION DOES NOT ESCAPE IT

This is the point that decides §13–§14, and it is worth stating flatly. Suppose you take Fronterotta’s route and make **P** separate. You still owe an account of why pa, pb and pc are pious — and Plato’s account, in the dialogue where the Forms are least in doubt, is **presence**:

*nothing else makes it beautiful other than **the presence or communion or however and in whatever way it comes on** of that beautiful; for I don’t make any further claims about that, but [I do claim] that [it is] by the beautiful that all beautiful [things are] beautiful.*

Phaedo 100c–d, trans. Dancy, “Platonic Definitions and Forms” p. 83

Separation relocates the Form; it does not remove the “in.” **Parmenides’ dilemma is aimed at the middle-period theory, not the *Euthyphro*** — which is exactly what Fronterotta concedes when he says the problem “is left unsolved even in middle and late dialogues” 2007: 56. The downward objection is an objection to *methexis*. It cannot be used to choose between an immanent and a separated reading, because both must answer it.

Upward: the abstraction reading is refuted by the texts themselves

Suppose one avoids the downward dilemma by demoting **P** — not a real one-in-many but a generalisation we form from the instances. That is the conceptualist or abstractionist reading, and three considerations close it.

WHY ABSTRACTION FAILS

1 Circularity

To abstract **P** from pa, pb, pc you must first have grouped those three as the relevant ones. What licensed the grouping? If **P** did, **P** was presupposed and not derived.

2 Regress

If something else licensed it — call it **Q** — then **Q** is doing the work **P** was to do, and the question restarts on **Q**.

3 Resemblance in a respect

If the grouping rested on resemblance: resemblance is always resemblance *in some respect*, and the respect is a universal. One may eliminate every universal but that one, and be left with a worse theory holding a universal anyway.

AND THE TEXT SAYS SO FIRST

4 It is why Socrates refuses definition by example

E2 is the upward argument in Plato's own words: not "one or two of the many pious actions" but **"that form itself that makes all pious actions pious"** — and he wants it **"so that I may look upon it, and using it as a model, say that any action of yours that is of that kind is pious, and if it is not that it is not"** (6d-e). The form is not a summary of the list. It is what makes the list a list.

5 Allen states it as a biconditional

"To say that Forms exist is to say that real definition should be pursued; to say that real definition should be pursued is to say that Forms exist" **1970: 68** . And forms "define the conditions for deciding when dialectic has succeeded, and when it has failed" **67–8** .

6 Fine fixes the direction of the “in virtue of”

A realist one over many posits universals **to explain sameness of nature**: “if a group of objects are all F, they are F **in virtue of** sharing a genuine property” 1993: 50. The sameness is explained by the universal, not recorded by it.

What the pair forces: immanent realism, with two priorities kept apart

Downward rules out treating the form as a body divided among its instances. Upward rules out treating it as a generalisation drawn from them. What is left is the position Prior names but never defends — “As Aristotle saw, a theory of universals” 2004: 4 — provided one distinction is observed.

TWO PRIORITIES, AND ONLY ONE OF THEM IS AT ISSUE

Ontological — the form is prior

pa, pb and pc are pious **in virtue of P**. P does not depend on them for being what it is. No circle: the upward objection is answered.

Epistemic — the instances come first

We have true beliefs about the instances before we know the form. The list is provisional and revisable. Which is what lets an elenchus begin at all.

Fine draws the line in one sentence: “We can correctly **believe** that a particular action is just without knowing what justice is; but we cannot **know** whether anything is just without knowing what justice is” 1993: 49.

And she notes the consequence for method: definitions “are generally tested against examples of Fs and against various beliefs about Fs” 1993: 49. Ordinary usage supplies a candidate list; the inquiry is the attempt to find what would vindicate or correct it; and the dialogues end in *aporia* because the list keeps turning out to have been assembled wrongly.

Note what this does to the modal question. On Fine’s own definition — “A is separate from B just in case A can exist without B” 1993: 51 — a form can be **explanatorily prior** to its instances and **modally dependent** on having some. That is immanent realism, and it is a coherent position, not a hybrid. It is also exactly what Prior needs. It is, equally, what he forfeits at §12 by making separation a change in category rather than a modal fact.

The cost — and a second worked instance of the structural-fit argument

The upward answer has a price, and the price is the interesting part. What it commits Socrates to is the **Priority of Definition** principle — Dancy’s Intellectualist Assumption, others’ Socratic Fallacy. *Meno* 71b states it flatly: if I do not know what a thing is, how could I know what qualities it has?

And Plato gives it up. Dancy’s account of the *Meno*, in his own words:

*The Doctrine of Recollection, the retraction of the Intellectualist Assumption, and the Method of Hypothesis are **hardly Socratic**, if we take the dialogues discussed above as our touchstone of Socraticism. So it looks very much as if, in the *Meno*, we have **Plato striking out on his own**. He is, it appears, now prepared to allow that **we can use terms in the absence of an explicit definition**, and that, when definitions are required, our way of getting at them is due to our prenatal grasp of what is to be defined.*

Dancy, “Platonic Definitions and Forms” p. 81

1 · The demand. *Euthyphro* 6d–e — the answer must be the form, not an instance, because the instances cannot be collected without it.

↓ **generates**

2 · The difficulty. *Meno* 80d — if you do not know what you are looking for you cannot look; if you do, you need not.

↓ **repaired by**

3 · The machinery. Recollection; the belief/knowledge gap; the Method of Hypothesis; and the retraction of the priority principle at *Meno* 86c–e.

WHY THIS MATTERS BEYOND THE CHAPTER

That is a **defect and a repair too closely fitted to each other to be independent** — the same form of argument the companion review runs on the elenchus (*Gorgias* → *Meno*), appearing here on a different axis, in a different dialogue pair, discovered from a different starting point.

And it is **orderable without a date**. You can state the *Euthyphro*’s demand without any of the *Meno*’s apparatus; you cannot state the *Meno*’s repair without a difficulty for it to repair. That is one ordered pair, paid for by the texts — which is the whole price the logical-first position asks.

So the one-over-many worry is not a problem for the early theory. It is what drives the corpus forward, and it is a second instance of the only kind of development that survives the collapse of the chronology.

TWO THINGS THIS DOES NOT SETTLE

1 · Immanent realism is a position, not a proof. Saying that “universal” names the category for which whole/part exhaustion fails answers Parmenides only if one is entitled to the category. A nominalist will say the category was invented to make the objection go away. Nothing above closes that off; it shows only that the objection does not discriminate between Prior and Fronterotta.

2 · Self-predication has to be read broadly, or the regress returns. If **P** is itself pious (Prior’s feature 7) in the same way *pa* is, then **P** joins the collection and a Third Man begins. Prior says his unseparated theory “does not appear to be a version that gives rise... to an infinite regress” p. 92, and that is right — but only because he is tacitly taking Fine’s **broad** self-predication, on which the form is *F* “in a *sui generis* way, simply in virtue of its explanatory role” Fine 1993: 52–3. He does not say so.

HOW GOOD IS THE ARGUMENT?

The functional argument is the strongest thing in the chapter, and it is the one move that could not be replaced by a threshold stipulation. It has a testable form: identify a question, show it is absent from a body of texts, show a doctrine that answers it, and conclude that the doctrine is later. Nothing in it depends on how much a set of claims must contain to be metaphysical.

But two things weaken it. First, it is Allen’s argument, and Prior applies rather than extends it. Second, Prior has just conceded that the *other* cause of separation — the Argument from Relativity — is adumbrated in the *Hippias Major*. If separation has two motives and one of them is present early, Fronterotta can say the germ is there, which is all he claimed (“the germ (at least) of separation”). The reply defeats the strong version of Fronterotta’s thesis and leaves the weak one standing.

And there is a dating dependency. The argument needs the *Meno* to be later than the definitional dialogues and the *Phaedo* later than the *Meno*. Prior’s note 2 says he is “suspicious of the chronological basis” for exactly this division — see §17.

CODA

ABOUT THIS PART

Prior’s own position, stated systematically at the end rather than defended at the start.

IN SHORT

Seven features, offered as crossing the threshold “as a body”; a candidate for where the threshold lies; and a footnote in which the chapter disowns its own framework.

Sections 15–19

the seven features · the threshold · note 2 · what is settled · the map

04

The positive case, at last

Prior is explicit about the order: “In the course of doing so I have presented my own view in the form of a critique of Vlastos’s position. In this concluding section I would like to present my view in a more systematic way than I have done so far” p. 91 . The five confrontations were the argument; the summary comes afterwards.

He is also unusually frank about how much it establishes: “I am well aware that those holding other views may find my position unpersuasive. I hope, however, that **some readers may be convinced**” p. 91 .

Bottom line: the case is cumulative by design. No single feature is claimed to be decisive.

15 The seven features

“It is true that all of these claims are not found in a single text, but E1 and E2 come close to a complete statement of the theory.”

#	THE FEATURE	WHERE PRIOR LOCATES IT	WHO GRANTS IT
1	Use of the language of the middle-period theory: <i>eidos</i> , <i>idea</i> , <i>paradeigma</i>	E1, E2	All five
2	That things corresponding to abstract terms such as “justice” exist	<i>Protagoras</i> 330c–d; <i>Hippias Major</i> 287b–d	All five — but Dancy reads the concessions as securing only “something to be defined”

#	THE FEATURE	WHERE PRIOR LOCATES IT	WHO GRANTS IT
3	That these things are the objects of real definition — things in the world, not linguistic terms	Allen's argument, adopted	Allen, Fine, Fronterotta; not Dancy (§06)
4	That they are ones over many , universals	E1, E2; Prior's n. 4 notes that a fully general statement of the principle does not appear before <i>Republic</i> X 596a	All five — and Prior's own candidate for the threshold
5	That they are causes of some sort	"through one form" (E2); <i>Hippias Major's</i> "by justice things are just"	All five; Dancy classes the mechanism as "a piece of metaphysics"
6	That they are standards	<i>paradeigmati</i> (E2, e6)	All five; it is Dancy's own Paradigm Requirement
7	That they are self-predicational	<i>Protagoras</i> 330c–e; derived from 6	All five, with Fine distinguishing narrow from broad

The structural claim. "Together these seven features constitute a theory of forms, as Allen states. **They constitute the basis of the theory of separately existing Forms in the 'middle' Platonic dialogues. Only the separate existence of the Forms, the 'gulf of deficiency' between Forms and phenomena, is not maintained.** I do not find it plausible to argue that this premise alone is sufficient to turn a metaphysically innocent set of claims into a metaphysical theory." p. 92

The coherence argument

Prior adds a second argument, which is about the dialogues as a group rather than the passages as a set:

*I have a further argument in favour of the ‘metaphysical’ interpretation... It ties together at least some of these dialogues into a neat whole. The dialogues I have in mind are the dialogues of definition: the Euthyphro, Charmides, Laches, Hippias Major, Republic I, Lysis, Meno and (perhaps) Protagoras... According to the account I adopt, it is a **search for real beings**... If one rejects this account, it seems to me that one must say either that the search is **purely linguistic** in character, or **refuse to provide an answer at all**. The attempt to ‘read out’ the ontological theory from the dialogues one by one **runs afoul of E1 and E2**; why not assume, therefore, that when Socrates is seeking definitions he is seeking forms?*

Prior p. 92

And a note on internal coherence: the theory “posits the existence of the objects it seeks to define, assigns a causal role to them and assigns a role as standards as well. The latter claim gives rise to a version of self-predication, but it does not appear to be a version that gives rise (if any in fact does) to **an infinite regress**” p. 92. That is a pointed remark: the Third Man is a problem for the *separated* Forms, and the unseparated theory escapes it.

THE DILEMMA IN THE COHERENCE ARGUMENT, TESTED

Prior offers three options and dismisses two. Is the trichotomy exhaustive?

Option A — purely linguistic. Ruled out by E2’s *paradeigmati* and by Allen’s point that a nominal definition would not need a standard to look upon. Fairly ruled out.

Option B — refuse an answer. Not really a position, and Prior treats it as a concession.

But there is an Option C he does not list, and it is Dancy’s: the search is for *conditions of adequacy on answers* — neither linguistic nor ontological, but normative. Dancy’s three requirements are exactly that, and his p. 11 statement (§05) makes the point explicitly: he is describing “what is required by the argument,” not what exists. The dilemma therefore does not close, and the coherence argument inherits the threshold problem rather than escaping it.

16 Where the threshold actually lies

The chapter’s real result, and it is not the one advertised.

Prior asks, at the end, why Dancy and Vlastos refuse a conclusion he thinks the text supports, and he answers it in the vocabulary of a threshold — using the word for the first and only time:

Perhaps because they hold the view I rejected above, that **only the inclusion of separate existence** among the premises of the theory of forms renders it metaphysically significant. What Vlastos called Plato's 'grandiose theory of "separately existing" Forms' would be a metaphysical theory; anything less 'grandiose' would not be. **Perhaps the question is seen as a 'threshold problem': what does it take to make a theory cross the threshold from metaphysical innocence to metaphysical significance;** their answer being, 'the doctrine of separate existence'. As noted above, I find this implausible. **I do not think this is a reasonable place to put the threshold.**

Prior p. 92

And then, in the next breath, the admission:

Exactly where the threshold of metaphysical significance lies is uncertain; if I had to select a single principle that gave this theory metaphysical significance, it would be the '**one over many**' principle (4 above), which introduces the idea of forms as universals. In fact, however, I think the seven principles I outlined above constitute a single theory that **crosses the threshold of metaphysical significance, wherever it lies, as a body.**

Prior p. 92

WHAT THIS CONCEDES

i The symmetry Prior does not name

At p. 75 the charge against Dancy was that he “does not offer an account of what makes a theory metaphysically innocent.” At p. 92 Prior says the location of that same line is “uncertain.” Neither party has the account. The difference is that Dancy’s argument requires the line and Prior’s does not — which is a real advantage, but a smaller one than the chapter’s rhetoric suggests.

ii “As a body” is the actual thesis

The claim is not that any feature is sufficient. It is that the conjunction of seven is enough on any reasonable placement of the line. That is a respectable form of argument — and it is unfalsifiable in exactly the way a threshold claim is, since a sceptic can always place the line above the conjunction.

WHAT IT ESTABLISHES ANYWAY

iii The dispute has been misdescribed for forty years

This is the finding worth keeping. From Allen 1970 to Fronterotta 2007 the debate has been conducted as though it were about what E1 and E2 say. It is not. All parties read them alike. The disagreement is about a criterion of metaphysical significance that no participant states and only one — Vlastos, with “reflective investigation” — even attempts.

iv And the criterion that is attempted fails its own test

Vlastos’s criterion is the only explicit one on offer, and §08 disposes of it: Socrates does not ask “What is form?” in the *Phaedo* or *Republic* either. So the field’s single stated threshold, applied evenly, does not divide the corpus where the field wants it divided.

16.1 · The criterion Prior cites and does not use

There is a principled answer available, it is published, it predates the debate by half a century, and Prior names it in a footnote.

Prior 2004 carries a note attached to his use of Quine’s criterion of ontological commitment. It is four sentences long, and it points at the one paper in the analytic tradition whose entire subject is the question the chapter cannot settle:

*My own views about ontological commitment are shaped by my understanding of Rudolf Carnap's classic essay 'Empiricism, Semantics and Ontology', Revue internationale de philosophie, 4 (1950), 20–40. I believe that what I say here is in line with Carnap's view, but **I am aware that a specialist in ontology might disagree.***

Prior, "Socrates Metaphysician" 2004: 8 n. 13

That hedge is carrying more weight than Prior knew. Carnap's paper does three things to this debate, and only the first is good news for him.

One — Carnap supplies the missing criterion, and it is sharp

Carnap's question is when a body of talk counts as having introduced a **framework of entities**. His answer is explicit, and it is two steps:

*The two essential steps are rather the following. **First, the introduction of a general term, a predicate of higher level, for the new kind of entities**, permitting us to say of any particular entity that it belongs to this kind (e.g., "Red is a property", "Five is a number"). **Second, the introduction of variables of the new type**. The new entities are values of these variables; the constants ... are substitutable for the variables. With the help of the variables, general sentences concerning the new entities can be formulated.*

Carnap, "Empiricism, Semantics, and Ontology" §III

Carnap attaches a footnote to the second step crediting the man Prior actually quotes: "**W. V. Quine was the first to recognize the importance of the introduction of variables as indicating the acceptance of entities**" — and then quotes the bound-variable formula itself §III n. 3. So Prior's Quinean argument at 2004: 7–8 and Carnap's second step are the same test.

Now apply both steps to the proof texts. They are not a close call.

THE EUTHYPHRO AGAINST CARNAP'S TWO STEPS

Step 1 — a general term of higher level

Carnap's examples are "Red is a property" and "Five is a number." E2 gives the form directly: what is sought is **"that form (*eidos*) itself that makes all pious actions pious"** — the pious is *an eidos*, a member of a kind of entity named by a higher-level term. E1 does it too, with *idea*.

Step 2 — variables of the new type

"Everything that is to be impious presents us with one form" (E1); **"all** impious actions are impious and **all** pious actions pious through one form" (E2). General sentences quantifying over the new entities, with instances substitutable. That is the bound-variable test, met on the page.

By Carnap's criterion the *Euthyphro* introduces the framework. Not "crosses a threshold wherever it lies" — meets a stated, published, independent test that was not devised for this dispute and has no stake in it.

WHAT THAT IS WORTH

It is the argument §15 needed and did not have. Prior's seven features are offered as crossing a line he admits he cannot locate; Carnap's two steps *are* a location, given in advance, by someone with no interest in Socrates. And the test is **textual and decidable**: you check whether a higher-level general term appears and whether the talk quantifies. No chronology, no threshold, no intuition about what is "grandiose" enough.

Two — Carnap vindicates Vlastos's observation and destroys his inference

Vlastos's central argument was that assent comes too easily for a theory to be present. Set his sentence beside Carnap's on internal existence questions:

VLASTOS

i The datum

“A belief is not a theory if everyone’s agreement with it can be presumed as a matter of course — if it is unproblematic for everyone, in need of explanation and justification for no one” 1991: 59 .

CARNAP

ii The same datum, correctly diagnosed

An internal existence claim is “analytic ... and even trivial ... because it does not say more than that the new system is not empty.” Hence “**nobody who meant the question ... in the internal sense would either assert or even seriously consider a negative answer**” §II .

They report the same fact and draw opposite conclusions. Protagoras agrees instantly that justice is *pragma ti* because, on Carnap’s account, he is being asked an **internal** question, and internal existence questions are trivially affirmative *once the framework is in place*. The ease of assent is not evidence that no framework was introduced. **It is the signature of one having been.**

And this sharpens Prior’s best evidence rather than merely supporting it. His answer to Vlastos is that *Meno* does not assent — he rejects the bee comparison, and the rejection produces the paradox p. 82 . On the Carnapian reading that is exactly what one would expect at the point where an internal question is pushed toward an external one. **The *Meno* is where the framework stops being taken for granted**, and *Meno*’s paradox is what asking the external question costs.

Three — and then Carnap takes from Prior the thing he most wants

Carnap’s whole purpose is to separate *having a framework* from *asserting a metaphysics*, and he is unsparing about it:

Thus it is clear that the acceptance of a framework must not be regarded as implying a metaphysical doctrine concerning the reality of the entities in question. ... An alleged statement of the reality of the framework of entities is a pseudo-statement without cognitive content.

Carnap §III

And when he reaches the framework that matters here — properties of things, the exact case of piety — he names the resulting thesis, and names it as his example of a pseudo-question:

*New rules are laid down which admit sentences like “Red is a property”, “Red is a color”, “These two pieces of paper have at least one color in common” ... The last sentence is an internal assertion. It is of an empirical, factual nature. However, the external statement, **the philosophical statement of the reality of properties — a special case of the thesis of the reality of universals — is devoid of cognitive content.***

Carnap §II, “The framework of thing properties”

THE POSITION PRIOR IS LEFT IN

“Socratic forms are real universals” is, verbatim, the thesis Carnap picks out as his specimen of a statement devoid of cognitive content. **Prior cites, as the source of his views on ontological commitment, a paper whose headline example of a meaningless question is his own conclusion.**

He is not careless about this — the note admits “a specialist in ontology might disagree.” But the disagreement is not marginal. It is total, and it is about the one question the chapter exists to answer.

And the two authorities Prior leans on are opposed on exactly this

Prior grounds the positive argument in Quine’s criterion and grounds his understanding of ontological commitment in Carnap. Carnap flags the incompatibility himself, in the same paper:

*Quine does not acknowledge the distinction which I emphasize above, because according to his general conception there are no sharp boundary lines between logical and factual truth, between questions of meaning and questions of fact, **between the acceptance of a language structure and the acceptance of an assertion formulated in the language.***

Carnap §III n. 5, on Quine’s “On What There Is”

For Quine there is no internal/external line, so “is Socrates committed to forms?” is a real question with a real answer — and Prior’s bound-variable argument goes through. For Carnap the line holds, so the same question splits into a trivial internal one and a meaningless external one — and Prior’s conclusion evaporates. **You may have the Quinean argument or the Carnapian foundation. Not both.**

WHAT SURVIVES ON EACH HORN

Take Quine

Prior's argument stands as he gives it: Socrates quantifies over forms, therefore he is ontologically committed to them, therefore he is an ontologist. The cost is that Prior must drop note 13, and with it any claim that his position is Carnapian.

Take Carnap

The *Euthyphro* demonstrably introduces the framework, by a stated test, against Dancy and Vlastos. But "and the forms are really universals" is not a further truth to be established — it is the external statement, and it says nothing. The result is **deflationary and textual**, and it settles less than Prior wants while settling it much more firmly.

Either way the "threshold" framing goes. On Quine there is no threshold, only commitment. On Carnap there is no threshold, only a framework and a pseudo-question about it.

The result worth keeping. On the Carnapian route the chapter's conclusion becomes: *the Euthyphro introduces a framework of forms; the early dialogues use it internally throughout; and the external question about that framework is first raised in the Parmenides*. Every clause of that is checkable against the text, none requires a date, and none requires anyone to say how grandiose a theory has to be. It is a smaller claim than Prior's and it is the one his own footnote was pointing at.

TWO CAUTIONS BEFORE THIS IS USED

1 · Carnap is not a neutral referee. The internal/external distinction is itself contested — Quine’s attack on it in “Two Dogmas” and “On Carnap’s Views on Ontology” is one of the most consequential arguments in twentieth-century philosophy, and it is not settled. Using Carnap to adjudicate is taking a side, not standing above the dispute. The honest claim is narrower:

Carnap offers the only stated criterion in the vicinity, and the Euthyphro meets it.

2 · Framework-introduction is not the theory of Forms. Meeting Carnap’s two steps shows that Socrates is talking about forms as entities of a kind. It does not show they are causes, standards, self-predicative or separate — features 5 to 7 of §15 are untouched by it. What Carnap settles is the part of the dispute that was about *whether there is an ontology here at all*. The part about *what kind* remains exactly where §§09–14 left it.

17 The premise Prior does not believe — note 2

Two sentences at p. 337 that change how the whole chapter should be read.

The question of the chapter — *does the Socrates of the early dialogues have an ontology?* — presupposes that there is an early group, identified independently, whose contents can be treated as a stage. Prior states the presupposition, and disowns it, in an endnote:

I am suspicious of the chronological basis for the division of the first two groups of dialogues, but it is necessary to generate the problem of this essay and it is the basis for several of the essays I shall discuss. I therefore follow the convention of referring to ‘early’ or ‘Socratic’ and ‘middle’ dialogues in this essay.

Prior, “Socratic Metaphysics” n. 2, p. 337

WHAT THIS DOES TO THE CHAPTER

Nothing, to most of it. The seven features are read off E1 and E2, and their being a theory does not depend on when the *Euthyphro* was written. The reply to Vlastos runs on Quine’s criterion and on Meno’s resistance, neither of which is a dating claim. The reply to Dancy is about a threshold. Fine’s reading of Aristotle is about Aristotle.

Everything, to one part. The reply to Fronterotta at §14 needs the *Meno*’s paradox to be *later* than the definitional dialogues and the *Phaedo* to be later than the *Meno*. Take away the chronological division Prior distrusts and the functional argument becomes an argument about the **order of dependence among the arguments** rather than about dates — which is a stronger position, not a weaker one, but it is not the one the chapter states.

The same note carries a second admission of the same kind, in Prior’s note 1: the “Forms”/“forms” capitalisation convention that the entire chapter runs on is Dancy’s — “In this essay I follow the convention of Russell Dancy in referring to the separately existing Forms of the *Phd.*, *Smp.* and *R.* as ‘Forms’ and the unseparated forms of the *Euthphr.* and other Socratic dialogues as ‘forms’.” So the notation presupposes the answer: it builds separation into the orthography and then asks whether separation makes the difference.

Read together, the two notes say this: the chapter accepts a chronological framework its author distrusts and a notation supplied by the opponent it is refuting, because the question cannot be posed without them. That is not a criticism of Prior — he says it himself, on the record. It is a description of how confined the question is.

18 What the chapter establishes, and what it leaves open

18.0 · The internal audit — seven tensions, graded

Several claims in this review amount to charges against Prior’s argument. They are scattered across §§06–17, and a charge stated in passing is easy to make and hard to check. They are collected here, each with the two passages that conflict and a verdict on how serious it is.

THE GRADING USED

Contradiction — two claims that cannot both be true. **Unmarked switch** — a term used in one sense here and another there, both load-bearing, with no notice given. **Non sequitur** — the conclusion does not follow from the stated criterion. **Misattribution** — alignment claimed with a position that rejects the conclusion. **Overstatement** — agreement or disagreement described inaccurately. **Disowned premise** — a premise used that the author says elsewhere he distrusts.

Only one item below is a strict contradiction. That is not a concession made reluctantly: overcharging here would repeat the fault the chapter itself commits against Dancy.

#	THE CONFLICT	WHERE	VERDICT
1	Self-predication read broadly to escape the regress, and narrowly to make Forms substances	pp. 92 and 93 — facing pages	Unmarked switch , and the closest thing to a contradiction in the chapter
2	Separation is a “strict incompatibility” and a change of ontological category — and also not enough to matter	2004: 14 vs pp. 92–93	Contradiction , or else an unstated distinction he owes

#	THE CONFLICT	WHERE	VERDICT
3	Quine's criterion yields <i>commitment</i> ; the conclusion asserted is <i>having a theory</i>	p. 80; 2004: 7–8	Non sequitur — the gap is real and unbridged
4	Ontological commitment grounded in Carnap, whose paper voids the conclusion	2004: 8 n. 13	Misattribution , not contradiction
5	"Complete agreement" with Fine, alongside rejection of her central claim about the middle dialogues	p. 93, one sentence apart	Overstatement
6	Dancy is faulted for having no account of the threshold; Prior says its location is "uncertain"	p. 75 vs p. 92	Asymmetry of burden , defensible but unacknowledged
7	The reply to Fronterotta needs an ordering the author says he is suspicious of	p. 90 vs n. 2, p. 337	Disowned premise

1 · The self-predication switch — facing pages

This is the sharpest one, and it is contained entirely within the Conclusion. On p. 92, arguing that the unseparated theory is internally sound:

*This metaphysical theory is, moreover, highly coherent. It posits the existence of the objects it seeks to define, assigns a causal role to them and assigns a role as standards as well. The latter claim gives rise to a version of self-predication, but **it does not appear to be a version that gives rise (if any in fact does) to an infinite regress.***

Prior p. 92

On p. 93, distinguishing himself from Fine:

*I think that separation transforms forms into Forms, properties into substances. This leads to **a new concept of self-predication, according to which Forms become perfect instances of their relevant properties**, and participation becomes resemblance to that instance.*

Prior p. 93

WHY THEY CONFLICT

The p. 92 claim is true only on **broad** self-predication — Fine’s BSP, on which the form is F “in a sui generis way, simply in virtue of its explanatory role” **Fine 1993: 52–3**. On the broad reading the form is not one more F thing, so no Third Man starts.

The p. 93 claim is **narrow** self-predication by definition: a “perfect instance” is an instance, and participation as “resemblance to that instance” is precisely the structure the Third Man exploits.

Both are load-bearing. Item (7) of the seven features is “that they are self-predicational” — and which reading it takes decides whether the theory is regress-free (p. 92) and whether separation changes the category of entity (p. 93). **Prior needs one reading on each page and marks neither.**

Is it a contradiction? Not quite, because p. 92 concerns the *early* theory and p. 93 the *middle* one, so he could consistently hold BSP early and NSP late. But then that *is* the argument for the property/substance thesis and it is never given — and Fine, whom he says he agrees with completely, argues that Plato holds BSP as well **1993: 62–3**. So the reading is available and undefended against the one opponent who has already closed it.

2 · Separation is decisive and not decisive

THE TWO CLAIMS

Separation is enormous

“The ontology of the elenctic dialogues differs from that of the middle dialogues only in a single respect: separation. **This is a huge difference and it is, strictly, an incompatibility**” **2004: 14**, at p. 82. And it “transforms forms into Forms, properties into substances” p. 93 — a change of ontological category.

Separation is not enough to matter

“Only the separate existence of the Forms ... is not maintained. **I do not find it plausible to argue that this premise alone is sufficient to turn a metaphysically innocent set of claims into a metaphysical theory**” p. 92.

A premise that is *strictly incompatible* with its negation and that *changes what kind of entity* is in question is an unusually strong candidate for the premise that makes the difference. Prior needs it to be both maximal against Fine and minimal against Dancy.

Verdict. This is the one place the charge of contradiction can be pressed. There is an escape: he could say separation makes a huge difference *within* metaphysics without being what makes something metaphysics at all — the difference between two ontologies rather than between ontology and non-ontology. That is coherent and is probably

what he means. **But he never says it**, and it is exactly the distinction the chapter most needs, because it is what would let him hold the anti-Dancy and anti-Fine positions together.

3 · Commitment is not theory — and Quine cannot supply the step

Prior's reply to Vlastos's "not a theory" charge is the bound-variable argument:

whether or not it counts as a theory, Socrates is ontologically committed to forms. According to Quine's criterion of ontological commitment, Socrates is committed to the existence of justice, piety and the like: he treats them as values of bound variables.

Prior p. 80, citing 2004: 7–8

Quine's criterion, in the formulation Carnap quotes, is a claim about a *language*: "The ontology to which one's use of language commits him comprises simply the objects that he treats as falling ... within the range of values of his variables." It says what a body of talk is committed to. **It says nothing about whether the speaker holds a theory**, and by design — the whole point of the criterion is to settle commitment without consulting the speaker's intentions.

So the criterion delivers less than the conclusion requires. Prior's own phrasing concedes it — "whether or not it counts as a theory" — and then the chapter concludes that Socrates "is a metaphysician, an ontologist, with a theory of forms." The gap between commitment and theory is the exact gap Vlastos's objection opened, and the Quinean argument steps over it rather than closing it.

4 · The Carnap attribution — and what it is *not*

§16.1 sets this out. One correction to how it is easy to state it: **this is not Prior contradicting himself**. He nowhere asserts both a proposition and its negation. He asserts a Quinean conclusion while believing it to be Carnapian, and Carnap's paper says in terms that the conclusion does not follow from the criterion — and names "the thesis of the reality of universals" as its specimen of a statement without cognitive content.

The right description is **misattribution of one's own position**. The damage is not logical but evidential: note 13 is the chapter's only stated ground for the criterion doing the heaviest work in the argument, and the ground does not support what is built on it.

5 · "Complete agreement", one sentence before the disagreement

I am in complete agreement with Fine's postulation of an early theory of forms, and especially with her treatment of early Platonic forms as properties. ... I do not think, however, that Fine is right to claim that the separated Forms of the middle dialogues continue to be properties.

Prior p. 93

Fine's thesis is that "Platonic forms are **not different entities** from Socratic forms" 1993: 64 . Rejecting that is rejecting her conclusion, not a detail. **Verdict: overstatement**, and a consequential one, since a reader takes "complete agreement" as licence not to check where the two accounts come apart — which is the very place item 1 above is hiding.

6 and 7 · The two already on the record

6 · THE THRESHOLD BURDEN

vi Defensible, unacknowledged

"He does not offer an account of what makes a theory metaphysically innocent" p. 75 against "Exactly where the threshold ... lies is uncertain" p. 92 . Prior has a good reply available — Dancy's argument *needs* the line and his does not — but he never makes it, and the chapter's rhetoric implies a bigger asymmetry than there is. See §16.

7 · THE DISOWNED ORDERING

vii Used, though distrusted

The reply to Fronterotta requires *Meno* after the definitional dialogues and *Phaedo* after *Meno* p. 90 . Note 2 says he is "suspicious of the chronological basis for the division." Using a premise dialectically is legitimate; asserting it without marking it as borrowed is not. See §17.

WHAT THE AUDIT ADDS UP TO

The chapter's reporting is sound. Nothing above touches the accuracy of its account of the five positions, which is careful and fair, or the two arguments that carry it: the parity argument against Vlastos's criterion (§08) and the functional argument against Fronterotta (§14). Those survive intact.

What the audit reaches is the positive thesis. Items 1, 2 and 3 are all failures at the same joint — the move from “there is an ontology in the early dialogues” (which Prior establishes) to “it is a metaphysical *theory* of real universals, and separation is a large difference that nevertheless does not decide metaphysical status” (which he asserts). Item 4 shows the only stated foundation for that move going the other way; item 5 shows the one opponent who blocks it described as an ally.

And the fix is available, which is why this is worth setting out rather than scoring. On the Carnapian route of §16.1 the joint is not crossed at all: the *Euthyphro* introduces a framework, that is demonstrable, and the further question about the reality of the universals is one Prior does not need to win. Items 1 to 5 are the cost of trying to win it.

ESTABLISHED

1. All five scholars read E1 and E2 the same way, and the dispute is not textual.
2. Dancy nowhere gives an account of metaphysical innocence, although his argument requires one. Zeyl's review reaches this independently.
3. Dancy concedes that the Transmission Theory is "a piece of metaphysics," and never asks what his whole package sums to.
4. Vlastos concedes the ontology in so many words (V1, pp. 57–58), which places him, on the question of whether there is a metaphysical view, with Allen, Fine and Prior rather than with Dancy.
5. Vlastos's stated criterion — reflective investigation, tested by whether Socrates asks "What is form?" — does not divide the corpus where he needs it to, because the *Phaedo* and *Republic* do not ask it either.
6. Vlastos's premise that assent is universal is false: Meno rejects the common-character comparison, and the rejection produces the paradox.
7. Two Worlds separation answers an epistemological question — how inquiry is possible — that the definitional dialogues do not raise.
8. The word "separation" carries two senses in this literature, and Allen's apparent disagreement with Prior turns on the equivocation.
9. Carnap's two-step test for framework introduction — a higher-level general term, and variables of the new type — is met by E1 and E2 on the page. The *Euthyphro* introduces a framework of forms by a stated, published, independent criterion (§16.1).
10. Prior grounds the positive argument in Quine and his understanding of ontological commitment in Carnap, and the two are incompatible on precisely this question — as Carnap says in the paper Prior cites (§III n. 5).
11. The separation criterion is Aristotle's mark of *Platonism*, inherited and repurposed as a mark of *metaphysics*. At M.9 Aristotle says Socrates was right not to separate (§00).
12. The one-over-many objection does not discriminate between the readings. Run downward it is *Parmenides* 131a–e, which targets the separated Forms; run upward it refutes abstractionism and so tells for the realist reading Prior, Allen and Fine share (§14.2).

NOT ESTABLISHED

1. That the seven features constitute a theory. Prior does not claim to have shown this; he claims they cross the threshold “wherever it lies,” and concedes the location is uncertain.
2. That separation converts properties into substances. Asserted at p. 93 against Fine, who has an account of self-predication that blocks the inference.
3. That the early forms are or are not separate in Allen’s *first* sense — numerical distinctness, independent existence, ontological priority. The chapter simply does not say.
4. That Fronterotta is wrong about the germ. The functional argument defeats the strong claim and leaves “the germ (at least) of separation” standing, since the Argument from Relativity is conceded to be adumbrated in the *Hippias Major*.
5. That any of this is independent of the chronology. Section 14 is not, and note 2 says the author distrusts the chronology.
6. That Socratic forms are *real universals* in the sense Prior intends. On Carnap that is the external statement about the framework, and “the philosophical statement of the reality of properties — a special case of the thesis of the reality of universals — is devoid of cognitive content.” On Quine it is establishable, but then the Carnapian foundation goes (§16.1).
7. That Fronterotta’s immanence/universality objection has been met. It is never addressed (§14.1). Three answers are available from sources Prior endorses; one of them — Allen’s — he cannot use without conceding separation, and the one he can use he half-takes and then undoes at §12.

THE CHAPTER’S SHAPE, RESTATED**Why five sections and not one**

Because the five denials have no common premise. Dancy’s rests on a distinction between definitional and metaphysical claims; Vlastos’s on a criterion of reflective investigation; Allen’s on distrust of Aristotle; Fine’s on an account of self-predication; Fronterotta’s on an inference from universality to non-physicality. Refuting any one leaves the others untouched.

What replaces the missing common premise

A threshold that nobody draws. Once that is seen, the five positions line up on a single axis — how much a set of claims must contain — and the textual disagreements turn out to be consequences of the placement rather than reasons for it.

Which is why the honest verdict on the chapter is: **it does not prove its thesis, and it does prove that nobody else has disproved it either.**

The one line to take away. Prior set out to show that the *Euthyphro* minus separation is still a metaphysical theory. What he showed is that the question cannot be settled without a criterion of metaphysical significance, that no party to a forty-year debate has supplied one, and that the only explicit candidate — Vlastos’s — fails when applied to the dialogues Vlastos himself calls metaphysical.

19 The whole thing as a map

Click a node to collapse or expand its branch. Drag to pan; hold Ctrl or ⌘ and scroll to zoom, or open it full screen.

The interactive argument map is available only in the web version of this review; it reproduces, as a collapsible tree, the structure set out in §§00 and 15–18.

SOURCES — EVERY PAGE REFERENCE VERIFIED AGAINST THE FILE, EXCEPT WHERE MARKED

- **Prior, William J.**, “Socratic Metaphysics,” ch. 4 of J. Bussanich and N. D. Smith (eds.), *The Bloomsbury Companion to Socrates* (London: Bloomsbury, 2012), pp. 68–93, with endnotes at p. 337. The chapter under review; read in full. Sections: Introduction (68–71) · Dancy’s View (71–5) · Critique of Dancy (75–6) · Vlastos’s View (76–9) · Critique of Vlastos (79–82) · Allen’s View (83–5) · Aristotle’s Testimony: Fine’s View (85–8) · Fronterotta’s View (88–90) · Critique of Fronterotta: The Problem of Separation (90–1) · Conclusion (91–3). Notes 1–17 at p. 337 — n. 1 (the Forms/forms convention, taken from Dancy), n. 2 (the disowned chronology), n. 3 (translations from Cooper 1997), n. 4 (the One over Many and *Republic* X 596a), n. 9 (Allen on separation “elsewhere”), n. 12 (Debra Nails pointed him to Fine 1993), n. 14 (“The relation to Allen’s view is clear”), nn. 15–16 (Fronterotta’s requirements mapped onto Dancy’s).

- **Dancy, R. M.**, *Plato's Introduction of Forms* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004) — held locally and quoted directly: the refusal of a chronological scheme and the “logical” development at p. 4; the Socratic/doctrinal groups at pp. 5–6; the statement that the denial concerns “what is required by the argument” and not Plato’s mind at p. 11; Aristotle’s genesis account at ch. 1.2, p. 12; the *Protagoras* at pp. 70–1; the *Hippias Major* and “here close doesn’t count” at pp. 77–8. **“Platonic Definitions and Forms,”** in H. H. Benson (ed.), *A Companion to Plato* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2006), pp. 70–84 — now held and quoted directly: the three requirements stated in full at p. 73; “where Socrates is concerned with definitions, he is not concerned with metaphysics at all (against this see, e.g., Allen 1970)” at p. 71; (SP), (SPs) and the Transmission Theory (TT1)–(TT3), with “a piece of metaphysics (although not yet the Theory of Forms),” at pp. 76–7; the *Hippias Major* refutation and (arE)–(arC), with “that requires a generalization Socrates does not give us” and “he is merely trying to defeat attempts to define the beautiful,” at pp. 78–9; “a massive shifting of gears” and “a far cry from an explicit Theory of Forms” at pp. 79–80; “in the *Meno*, we have Plato striking out on his own” at p. 81; *Phaedo* 100c–d and “This is the Theory of Forms, and its heritage is pretty clearly Socrates’ quest for definitions” at p. 83.
- **Vlastos, Gregory**, *Socrates: Ironist and Moral Philosopher* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1991), ch. 2 — held locally and quoted directly: the groups at pp. 46–7; Thesis IIA/IIB at p. 47; “the most powerful of the ten” at p. 53; T4 and T5 (*Euthyphro* 5d, 6d–e) and the two conditions at pp. 56–7; the ontological concession (V1) at pp. 57–8; the linguist analogy and “What is form? he never asks” at pp. 58–9; “A belief is not a theory” at p. 59, with n. 52 on Allen 1970 at the same page; the *Protagoras* and “turns it down” at pp. 62–3; T10 (R. 596a) and T11 (*Phd.* 100b) at p. 63; the four categorical features at pp. 66–73; “in bodies” at p. 74; *chorismos* at pp. 75–6; “the heart of Plato’s metaphysics” at p. 76; the Form-mysticism and the closing contrast at pp. 79–80.

- **Allen, R. E.**, *Plato's 'Euthyphro' and the Earlier Theory of Forms* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1970) — held locally and quoted directly: the theory as both logical and metaphysical, and the real-definition equivalence, at pp. 67–8; the *Sophist* 247e criterion, “a difference, to be a difference, should make a difference,” and Forms doing “honest work,” in the chapter on Essence and Reference; the referential theory of meaning at p. 125; Aristotle’s criteria of separation at p. 133 and the claim that the early forms are “just as separate” at p. 136, cf. p. 147; the two-worlds contrast at p. 154; the epistemological origin of separation at p. 157; cf. pp. 163–4; and **“The Immanence of Forms” at pp. 145–7**, answering Ross — the section used at §14.1. **“Plato’s Earlier Theory of Forms,”** in G. Vlastos (ed.), *The Philosophy of Socrates* (Garden City, NY: Doubleday, 1971), pp. 319–34 — the 1971 article is quoted as Prior quotes it (pp. 327–34), and cross-checked against the 1970 book where the same material appears.
- **Fine, Gail**, *On Ideas: Aristotle’s Criticism of Plato’s Theory of Forms* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1993), ch. 5, pp. 44–65 — now held and quoted directly: §4 “Socratic forms” at pp. 49–51, including the derivation of universality from immanence (“since the form of piety is in everything that is pious, it is simultaneously in more than one thing at a time”) and the realist/semantic one-over-many distinction after Armstrong at p. 50; the modal definition of separation at p. 51; F1–F3 in Fine’s translations of *Metaphysics* A.6 987a29–b8, M.4 1078b12–32 and M.9 1086a32–b13 at pp. 44–6; Heracliteanism and compresence at pp. 54–7; “Nothing said in the middle dialogues seems to me to involve clear commitment to separation” at pp. 60–1; NSP/BSP and perfect paradigmaticism at pp. 62–3; the conclusion at p. 64.
- **Fronterotta, Francesco**, “The Development of Plato’s Theory of Ideas and the ‘Socratic Question’,” *Oxford Studies in Ancient Philosophy* 32 (2007), pp. 37–62 — now held and quoted directly: the summary of Prior 2004 in three claims, with the immanence/universality parenthesis, at pp. 37–8; “anti-developmental” and the account of the term at p. 40 with n. 1; the causal-ontological turn at pp. 42–4; the three levels of agreement at p. 48; “beyond doubt... a theory of Ideas” at p. 49; §4 on the ontological status of Ideas and the unsolved presence problem at pp. 50–1 with n. 19; the three developmentalist assumptions (I)–(III), including “the problem is left unsolved even in middle and late dialogues,” at pp. 54–6; against Allen, and “a real and concrete separation between two kinds of beings,” at p. 57 with n. 30; “exegetical prejudice” at p. 58; the conclusion at p. 59.

- **Prior, William J.**, “Socrates Metaphysician,” *Oxford Studies in Ancient Philosophy* 27 (2004), pp. 1–14 — now held and quoted directly (the volume is an image scan; the text was recovered by OCR and each quotation checked against the rendered page): Allen quoted on separation at pp. 3–4; “What remains when the idea of ‘separation’ has been removed? As Aristotle saw, a theory of universals” at p. 4; the *Protagoras* at pp. 5–6 and the *Meno*’s bees at pp. 6–7; Vlastos 1988: 140 quoted (“forms existing only ‘in’ their instances”) and the difficulty about “theory,” with the reference to Annas, at p. 7; Quine’s criterion, with n. 13 on Carnap, at pp. 7–8; the *Parmenides* point at p. 8; identity statements and the parity argument at p. 9; “a theory of common properties... Without this metaphysical underpinning, Socratic moral enquiry cannot take place,” with n. 17 on Wittgenstein, at p. 10; the three replies on universal assent at pp. 11–13; the two conclusions at pp. 13–14.
- **Carnap, Rudolf**, “Empiricism, Semantics, and Ontology,” *Revue internationale de philosophie* 4 (1950), pp. 20–40 — held and quoted directly: the internal/external distinction and the triviality of internal existence claims at §II; the thing-properties framework and “the philosophical statement of the reality of properties — a special case of the thesis of the reality of universals — is devoid of cognitive content” at §II; the two essential steps for introducing a framework, with n. 3 crediting Quine for the bound-variable criterion, at §III; “the acceptance of a framework must not be regarded as implying a metaphysical doctrine” and n. 5 on Quine’s rejection of the distinction, at §III. Cited by Prior at 2004: 8 n. 13 and used at §16.1.
- **Zeyl, Donald**, review of Dancy 2004 — quoted at Prior pp. 75–6; the review itself has not been consulted.
- **Aristotle**, *Metaphysics* A.6 987a29–b8; M.4 1078b12–32 (esp. b30–31); M.9 1086a32–b13. **Plato**, *Euthyphro* 5c–d, 6d–e, 7e–8a, 9e–11b, 11a6–8; *Protagoras* 330b–e, 330c–331c; *Hippias Major* 287b–e, 287e–289d, 289b–d, 290c–d, 292e–293; *Meno* 72a–73a, 86c–e; *Phaedo* 65a–66a, 72e–78a, 74a–c, 74b–c, 100b, 100c–d; *Symposium* 210e–211b; *Republic* 479a–d, 523–5, 596a; *Laches* 191a–e; *Sophist* 247e–248b; *Theaetetus* 149a–151d. Translations: Grube in Cooper & Hutchinson (eds.), *Plato: Complete Works* (Indianapolis: Hackett, 1997), which is Prior’s default (his n. 3); Fine’s own for the Aristotle.

Claims marked as mine rather than Prior’s: the reading of the chapter as five non-reducible obstacles rather than one argument (§00); the placement of all five positions on a single threshold axis (§04, §16); the observation that Vlastos’s criterion, applied evenly, either promotes the *Euthyphro* or demotes the *Phaedo* (§08 — Prior makes the point, but not this consequence); the objection at §10 that Prior never says whether the early forms are separate in Allen’s first sense; the objection at §12 that the property/substance claim presupposes narrow self-predication against Fine’s argued broad version; the missing Option C in the

coherence dilemma (§15); the two premises reconstructed at §00 and the Aristotelian slide beneath the first of them; the application of Carnap's two-step test to E1 and E2, and the Quine–Carnap incompatibility in Prior's n. 13 (§16.1); and the reading of note 2 as making §14 a claim about dependence rather than dates (§17).